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TUESDAY
10TH MARCH, 2026

PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

FIRST MEETING, 2026

Tuesday, 10th March, 2026

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 1:43 p.m.*

[THE SPEAKER, RT HON ALBAN
SUMANA KINGSFORD BAGBIN,
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

The Speaker: Hon Members, we
move to the item numbered 4, Messages
from the President.

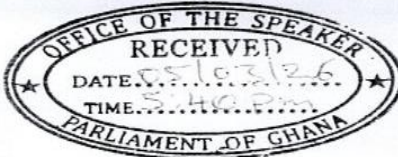
**COMMUNICATION FROM THE
PRESIDENT**

Absence from Ghana

The Speaker: I received a Message
from the President dated 5th March,
2026. It reads;


REPUBLIC OF GHANA

Jubilee House

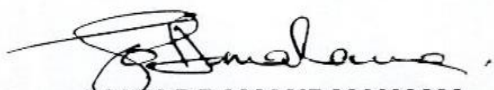

The President
5th March, 2026

Rt. Hon. Speaker,

ABSENCE FROM GHANA

In accordance with Article 59 of the 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana, I write to formally notify you of my intention to travel outside the country on Sunday, 8th March, 2026 to Seoul, Korea, for a working visit from 9th to 14th March 2026. I will return to Ghana on Sunday, 15th March, 2026.

In my absence, the Vice President, Professor Naana Jane Opoku-Agyemang, shall perform my duties in accordance with Article 60 (8) of the Constitution.


JOHN DRAMANI MAHAMA

**THE RT. HON. SPEAKER
OFFICE OF PARLIAMENT
PARLIAMENT HOUSE
ACCRA**

cc: The Vice President
Jubilee House
Accra

The Chief of Staff
Jubilee House
Accra

The Speaker: Hon Members, I also received from the Electoral Commission, the Writ of Summons on the Ayawaso East by-election held on 3rd March, 2026. I shall proceed to read the communication. —

Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I think it should be the Writ of Elections, just for the records.

The Speaker: Was there a slip of tongue?

Some Hon Members: Yes.

The Speaker: Sorry, I said “Writ of Summons”, it is rather the “Writ of Elections”. *[Laughter]* Kindly forgive me, I am no more in court. It is a Writ of Elections and it is dated 4th March, 2026.

ANNOUNCEMENT

Communication from the Electoral Commission

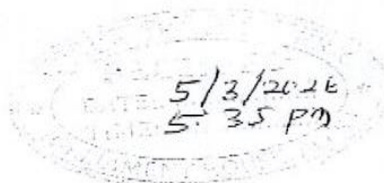
The Speaker: I would want the *Hansard* to capture the totality of the Writ of Elections. But I would read from the item numbered b, which is part of the Writ. It deals with the certificate to be endorsed on the Writ, which I believe is more important at this stage.



OUR REF.: C/EC.04/SF.05/V.1

4TH MARCH, 2026

THE CLERK TO PARLIAMENT
PARLIAMENT HOUSE
ACCRA.



Dear Sir,

**SUBMISSION OF WRIT OF ELECTION FOR THE AYAWASO EAST
PARLIAMENTARY BY-ELECTION HELD ON 3RD MARCH, 2026**

I bring you greetings from the Electoral Commission and trust that this letter finds you well.

Please find attached, the Writ of Election for the Ayawaso East Parliamentary By-Election held on Tuesday, 3rd March, 2026 in the Ayawaso East Constituency.

Also attached is a schedule containing the name of the Candidate elected pursuant to Regulation 43 (2b) of the Public Elections Regulations, 2020 C.I. 127

Thank you.

Yours faithfully,

MR. SAMUEL TETTEY
DEPUTY CHAIRMAN, OPERATIONS
for: **CHAIRPERSON**

5th Jomo Kenyatta Road, Ridge - Accra • P. O. Box M 214, Accra, Ghana
Tel: (0)233 303 968 750 • Fax: +233(0) 302 221 007 • email: info@ec.gov.gh • website: www.ec.gov.gh • GPS Address: GA-079-8032

**2026 PARLIAMENTARY BY-ELECTION
LIST OF ELECTED CANDIDATE**

REGION: GREATER ACCRA

S/NO	CONSTITUENCY	NAME OF ELECTED CANDIDATE	PARTY AFFILIATION	SEX	CONTACT NUMBER
1	AYAWASO EAST	BABA JAMAL MOHAMMED AHMED	NDC	MALE	0244770014



ELECTORAL COMMISSION
GHANA

FORM OF WRIT
PUBLIC ELECTIONS REGULATIONS, 2020 (C.I 127)

FORM ONE A

(regulation 4 (2))

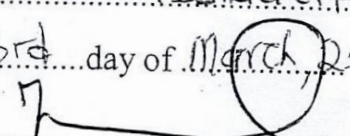
WRIT OF ELECTION

TO THE RETURNING OFFICER FOR THE AYAWASO
EAST.....CONSTITUENCY

WHEREAS elections are to be held for the election of a Member of Parliament;
WHEREAS there exists a vacancy in the Membership of Parliament for
the AYAWASO EAST.....Constituency;

NOW THEREFORE, I do hereby command that you cause the Election of
a Member of Parliament to be held in accordance with the law for the said
Constituency and that you do certify on this Writ the name of the person elected.

I DO HEREBY DIRECT that the Nomination shall take place from
the 9th day of FEBRUARY
to the 11th day of FEBRUARY at AYAWASO EAST DISTRICT OFFICE
and that the Poll shall be taken, if necessary, on the 3rd day of MARCH 2026


Chairperson, Electoral Commission

[P.T.O.]

FORM ONE B
(regulation 43 (1) (g))ELECTORAL COMMISSION
GHANA**CERTIFICATE TO BE ENDORSED ON WRIT**

I HEREBY CERTIFY that the Member of Parliament elected for the AYAWASO EAST
Constituency in pursuance of this Writ is BABA JAMAL MOHAMMED AHMED
and the number of votes cast in respect of each the Candidates at the election is as follows:

Candidates	Votes Obtained
1. <u>BABA JAMAL MOHAMMED AHMED</u>	<u>10,884</u>
2. <u>IBRAHIM IDRISU</u>	<u>43</u>
3. <u>YUSSIF ALI BABA</u>	<u>4,009</u>
4. <u>MOHAMMED UMAR SANDA</u>	<u>1,885</u>
5. <u>KANOR DAVID</u>	<u>107</u>
6.	
7.	
8.	
9.	
10.	

Date 03-03-2026 OR

Returning Officer

I HEREBY CERTIFY that at the expiration of the time allowed for the delivery of
Nomination Forms no Candidate stood duly nominated in the
Constituency.

Date..... OR

I HEREBY CERTIFY that, by reasons of the fact that an equal number of votes were found
to exist between the following Candidates.....

And by reason of the fact that the addition of a vote would have entitled any one of those
Candidates to be elected, no Member has been elected for the
..... Constituency.

Date..... OR

Returning Officer

E.L.1A

1:53 p.m.

The Speaker: So, Hon Members, it is my duty to definitely do what is expected of me today and that is to, on your behalf, swear in the person that the voters in the Ayawaso East Constituency have decided to elect as their Member of Parliament. So, pursuant to Standing Order 13 (1) of the Standing Orders of this House, I shall now invite the Hon Member-elect for Ayawaso East Constituency to proceed to the Speaker's dais to take the Oath of Allegiance and the Oath of a Member of Parliament. *[Hear! Hear!]*.

Hon Members, he is one of the Members we refer to here as, "I shall return." *[Hear! Hear!]* So, he is used to the drill.

OATHS

[Hon Baba Jamal Mohammed Ahmed took and subscribed to the Oath of Allegiance and Oath of a Member of Parliament] [Administered by the Rt Hon Speaker]

The Speaker: Now, you have voluntarily offered yourself to serve the good people of the Ayawaso East Constituency. In your campaign, you stated that you want to serve them as a Member of Parliament and by doing so serve Ghana. You do not want to serve Ghana as a High Commissioner in Nigeria.

I took note of those statements and I am going to hold you as my son. He knows what I mean by saying that. It is not the word of the general son I have

been using for all of you. This is different and he knows the import of that. I will hold you accountable to the good people of Ayawaso East Constituency. Serving them you must, and I would focus on you on this Floor to see how you perform in serving them. If you do not, I can assure you that I would be there to campaign against you in the next election. To facilitate your work, we definitely have to give you the basic tools to work with and the first is the Constitution of the Republic of Ghana, which you just swore to preserve, to protect, and to defend. This is the Constitution of the Republic of Ghana, 1992. We will also add the Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana.

[The Speaker presented copies of the 1992 Constitution and the Standing Orders of Parliament to the Member of Parliament for Ayawaso East Constituency.]

2:03 p.m.

The Speaker: These are the revised Standing Orders, effective 2nd January 2024. So, they are not the Standing Orders that you know because you were here before. Kindly take note, read them and ensure that you abide by them. The other documents will follow soon, but on behalf of the House, I want to congratulate you on winning the by-election. Your winning this by-election has also triggered urgent action in this House, so we have in this House a proposed Private Members' Bill which is meant to amend the Criminal and Other Offences Act to include conduct and acts during by-elections and also primaries of political parties. It is important I draw

attention to this, because we need all of you to come together for us to do what we believe is right. I will congratulate you because you followed what the law was, but we are now going to change that law and ensure that the sentiments and concerns that Ghanaians have raised become a binding law on all of us. In the meantime, you are congratulated, and you are welcome to this House. Thank you.

Hon Members, let me acknowledge the presence of some of our visitors. Because our doors are widely open, at every Sitting, we receive so many visitors, and it is our practice to always acknowledge their presence. We have visitors from three institutions today.

We have 64 of them coming from the Dar-Es Salam Islamic Basic School, which is located at Ledzokuku. They are led by their English language teacher, by name Mr Kwame Debrah Gyan. Please, you are warmly welcome to Parliament, your Parliament, and luckily, you witnessed one of the rarest occasions; the swearing in of a Member of Parliament after a by-election. So, that is a fortune for you. Also, take time to learn the other things that take place daily. On behalf of the House, I warmly welcome you. Please resume your seats.

[Pupils of the Dar-Es Salam Islamic Basic School were acknowledged]

The Speaker: We also have 65 visitors from Harmony International School, Sogakope, which is located in the South Tongu Constituency. They are being led by the Civic Education Officer,

by name, Mr Ernest Dedzo. You are also warmly welcome, and the same goes to you as I just communicated to your colleagues from the Dar-Es Salam Islamic Basic School. So, you may resume your seats.

[Pupils of the Harmony International Basic School, Sogakope, were acknowledged]

The Speaker: Last but not least, we have 35 visitors from Deacons Academy located in the Dome Kwabenya Constituency. They are led here by their supervisor by name Mr Soh Philip Yaw. You are also warmly welcome, and it is the same message to you, so you may kindly resume your seats.

[Pupils of the Deacons Academy were acknowledged.]

The Speaker: There are many more, but I have not received the list yet. As and when I receive the list, I will let Members know those who are here to observe proceedings of the House.

Hon Members, I will definitely grant an opportunity for your Leaders to say a few words of welcome to our youngest Member of Parliament. But it is important I say this before you come in. I gave my daughter in marriage to him some years ago. At the time, he was a young boy; now he is grown. His wife, my daughter, is here. I will just mention her name. Anywhere you see her, please, that is my daughter. She is now Mrs Rahinatu Baba Jamal. So, I do not feature anywhere there now. I will not hear what you are saying. *[Laughter]*

I want to give the opportunity to the Leaders to welcome him. I do not know whether the First Deputy Minority Whip wants to do that for and on behalf of the Minority Leader. Yes, you may do so.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr Speaker, let me, on behalf of my Colleagues from the Minority, welcome him.

The Speaker: Hon Members, in fact, my attention has been drawn to the fact that the National Chairman of the National Democratic Congress (NDC)—*[Hear! Hear!]*—and he is sparkingly dressed in white.

2:13 p.m.

Hon Johnson Asiedu Nketiah is one of the foundation members of this Parliament.

Yes, Minister for Roads and Highways, am I out of order?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, you can never be out of order, but I was surprised that when the Leader of the Minority decided to nominate somebody to speak, the Deputy Leader is sitting by the Leader and he decided to sideline the only Lady at the Front and give the opportunity—this is very surprising.

Mr Speaker, I am even told that Hon Patricia Appiagyei is going to be the running mate of Dr Bawumia and that is why he does not like her.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, when the NDC won, I advised Mr Kwame Agbodza to stay in leadership; he decided to go to the Ministry of Roads and Highways. I know he misses leadership. He has his Leaders here, yet anytime he comes, he wants to cause trouble; is it his matter? Mr Speaker, we have taken our decision. *[Interruption]* Mr Speaker, with that said, I am sure we would be having “friends of Baba Jamal” here. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, please, our respected Colleague, the First Deputy Minority Whip would take the bite on behalf of the Caucus.

First Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, let me, on behalf of my Colleagues, welcome the Member of Parliament for Ayawaso East and as he can observe, it is very clear that our Colleagues in the Majority are now trying to save their face, after having issued a letter of vote of no confidence in him. It was signed by the 189 Majority Caucus.

Mr Speaker, they said that the result of the primaries he won should be annulled since they do not have confidence in that process. They also said that they should not even allow him to participate again in any future primaries. The letter that was signed by the Regional Caucuses of the Majority, representing the 189 — Mr Speaker, they are not friends of Baba Jamal. They do not like him at all. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, he is welcome on our Side and it is very obvious that the only friend Baba Jamal has in the NDC —

because the President fired him before he was declared; the Majority denied him before he was declared. The only person who stood by him was the National Chairperson of the party. Mr Asiedu Nketia is the only friend he has in the Party; any other person is not his friend.

Mr Speaker, when we observe what is actually going on in the Chamber, I just want to advise Hon Baba Jamal that the Majority — even where he is seated is an indication that they do not like him at all. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, the Minority welcomes him, but we do not want *nkosua ne mako*. We do not want Televisions and we do not want motorbikes. The most important thing is that when he joins us, we would find out whether the *nkosua ne mako no, wo de biribi agu mu anaa*, because the way the election — Mr Speaker, the outcome of the election indicates that the NDC lost popularity in the Ayawaso East election.

Mr Speaker, in 2024, just one year ago, the NDC pulled 22,000 votes in the Constituency, representing 70 per cent. One year along the line, they could not pull anything up to 11,000 votes; from 22,000 to 10,888. It is an indication that Ghanaians are not happy with this Government. It is an indication that Ghanaians are aware of the setting of this Government.

So, Mr Speaker, it is not too late. He is too close to the Minority, so he can join us.

Mr Speaker, without much, I welcome him; I want to tell him that he is welcome to the family of 276, where we sit here as Brothers and Sisters. We will reach out to each other and as the Minority, we have welcomed him. Mr Speaker, he has seen that nobody from the Majority welcomed him and shook his hand; it is the Minority that are his friends. The Majority have not revoked their letter and their letter still stands. They do not believe in him and they believe that he should not be a Member of Parliament (MP), but we believe that he should be an MP.

Thank you, Mr Speaker. *[Hear! Hear!]*

The Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga (Majority Leader): Not long ago, our Friends on the other Side copiously signed petitions calling for the dismissal of their own Minister for Finance. This went down in history as unprecedented, where an entire Caucus will sign petitions calling for the dismissal of a sitting Minister for Finance and he was there. I am surprised that my Colleague, the Minority Leader, has passed the baton on to him to comment today and I knew the tangent he was going on, but he would have had difficulty going on that tangent because it would have pointed out to him that in his Constituency, Dr Bawumia lost woefully and abysmally. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, I do not know what the implications are in terms of the confidence that he had in Dr Bawumia as a Leader of his party or as a

flagbearer. But Mr Speaker, of course, in every human society, there are incidents; there are twists and there are turns. Ultimately, our Brother —

The Speaker: Majority Leader, sorry, I have to interrupt. I have to rush to another assignment and so, the First Deputy Speaker will take the Chair.

2:22 p.m. —

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR IN THE
CHAIR]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Leader, you may continue.

Mr Ayariga: So, Mr Speaker, ultimately, Hon Alhaji Baba Jamal is here in this Chamber. We on this Side warmly congratulate and welcome him into the Chamber. He is not a newcomer to this Chamber; he is a tried and tested hand in this Chamber.

Mr Speaker, I have no doubt that his presence in this Chamber is going to fortify the capacity of the Majority. He is known for his capacity to strike at the very heart of the opposition. As a Deputy General Secretary of the party, he led the struggle that restored the NDC to power and we are very proud of his track record. We believe that his addition to the Caucus is going to improve our capacity.

2:23 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I am very confident that the Leadership of this Side of the House has been strengthened by his presence.

As a lawyer of no mean practice background, he has been representing the NDC in many cases and he has built capacity. If joins us on this Side of the House, at least, we can unleash him on Mr Yaw Boamah and then we will deal with the rest. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, I believe Hon Baba Jamal knows the NDC and this Caucus very well and in no time, I believe, we will begin a good working relationship. As for the attempt by Hon Habib Iddrisu to misrepresent history, we will treat him with all the disdain and ignore him. We will not engage him along those tangents.

Alhaji Baba Jamal, you are welcome and congratulations. For a man to decide to leave the position of High Commissioner to the Federal Republic of Nigeria and to come and sit in this Chamber is an indication of his commitment to public service and to the people of Ayawaso East. We admire that. We respect that and we welcome him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me add my voice in congratulating Hon Baba Jamal and welcoming him to the Parliament of the Republic of Ghana.

Hon Members, thereafter, permit me to acknowledge the presence of chiefs, queen mothers and elders from Ayawaso East, led by Chief Louis. I also welcome tribal chiefs and mallams from the constituency to the Parliament of the Republic of Ghana.

Hon Members, on your behalf, I urge them to have a fruitful visit to Parliament.

[Chiefs, Queen Mothers, Elders and Mallams from Ayawaso East were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, can we take the *Votes and Proceedings* of Monday, 9th March, 2026.

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Monday, 9th March, 2026, for your correction.

[No correction was made to the Votes and Proceedings of 9th March, 2026]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we have a request by the Minister for Finance, acting through his Deputy, to make a Statement on some Government policy. We want you to allow him pursuant to Standing Order 91(2), to make a Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership, that is the application.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, we thought that at Conclave, that would have been brought up for discussions. This is some

sort of a surprise to us and it is unknown to us. The respected Clerk was also at Conclave. We agreed to take the debate and basically proceed with it. Mr Speaker, there is also a programme at 4 o'clock. All of this, we agreed that we will take some debaters and then we will proceed. I do not know whether that cannot be deferred to tomorrow, but we are entirely in your hands.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, being entirely in my hands, leave is hereby granted. Deputy Minister for Finance, you have the floor.

STATEMENT

Report of the Auditor-General on Arrears and Payables as at the End 2024

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem) (MP) *on behalf of the Minister for Finance:* Mr Speaker, I stand before you to deliver a Statement on behalf of Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, the Minister for Finance. The Statement is on the audit of the arrears as was reported to this House during the Mid-Year Budget Review.

Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity to make this Statement on a matter that is very important to this Republic. This is a Report on the systemic blunder and abuse of the public financial management system. By the time I am done with this presentation, it will become clear that something needs to be done to save our economy.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance informed this august House during the Mid-Year Review of the 2025 Budget of the ongoing audit of Government areas and commitments as at end 2024 and promised to submit same to this House when the process is completed.

The Ghana Audit Service working in partnership with Ernst & Young (EY) and [PricewaterhouseCoopers](#) (PWC), undertook an exercise to verify and validate a total of GHC68.7 billion submitted to the Ministry of Finance in unpaid Interim Payment Certificates (IPC), invoices and bank transfer advices owed to contractors and suppliers. Out of this, outstanding IPCs and invoices amounted to GHC50.5 billion while outstanding bank transfer advices amounted to GHC18.3 billion.

Findings

Mr Speaker, permit me to present some of the troubling findings of the audit. Out of the GHC68.7 billion submitted for audit, a total of GHC45.4 billion was deemed to be valid for payment. A total of GHC8.1 billion was rejected for various reasons including unsupported documentation, duplication, overstatement, already paid items, falsified stores receipt advice and no work done. About GHC1 billion of the outstanding Bank Transfer Advice (BTA), which refers to invoices and IPCs processed by Ministries, Department and Agencies (MDAs) in 2024, approved by the Ministry of Finance, submitted to Controller and Accountant General's Department (CAGD) and pending payment were

rejected. Mr Speaker, this GHC1 billion that was rejected by the audit would have been paid if the Ministry of Finance had not made a bold decision to stop payment in January 2025.

2:33 p.m.

About GHC7.1 billion of the outstanding IPCs and invoices which refers to requests by MDAs for payments to suppliers and contractors, and certified for payment by various public officers across the approval hierarchies have also been rejected. They were rejected for various reasons including absence of supporting documents, duplications, recycled invoices and IPCs, over-statements and no work done.

Again, an amount of GHC13.3 billion is yet to be validated for various reasons including lack of third-party confirmation, inadequate documentation and no supporting contracts.

Mr Speaker, fictitious debt of GHC89.4 million. The then Ministry of Trade and Industry in 2024 submitted a request of GHC89.4 million to the Ministry of Finance to be transferred to five commercial banks as government's contribution to interest payments under the One District, One Factory (1D1F) initiative. The Ministry of Finance subsequently processed same to the Controller and Accountant General's Department for payment.

But Mr Speaker, this particular request was part of BTAs sitting at the Controller and Accountant General's Department awaiting cash for payment.

When auditors contacted these five banks to confirm the liability, every single one of them denied being owed any amount by government under the said arrangement.

According to the auditors, the said GH¢89.4 million debt was fictitious. Without the audit intervention, a whopping GH¢89.4 million of hard-earned public money could have been disbursed to settle this non-existent liability.

Mr Speaker, only God knows how much of taxpayers' money has been lost to similar fictitious claims.

Mr Speaker, payment of GH¢10.5 million was recorded as having been made into an account named the "Buffer Account" at a commercial bank. Upon verification, the bank confirmed that it had never received such payment. The account number cited did not exist within the bank's records and did not even conform to its account numbering format. The evidence from the audit pointed to a completely fictitious account.

Mr Speaker, as a result of these fictitious accounts linked to the One district, One factory payments, the entire 1D1F scheme requires a forensic audit which will be carried out soon. Moreso when Government is said to have spent GH¢391 million as its contribution towards 1D1F interest subsidies as at the end of 2024.

The dry spell expenditure.

Mr Speaker, in 2024, the Government of Ghana paid for 34,000 metric tonnes

(MT) of rice to address the impact of the dry spell.

However, the Ministry of Food and Agriculture received and distributed 24,000MT of rice. To date, 10,000MT of rice remains unaccounted for even though the entire quantity has been fully paid for.

The Audit revealed that the Government of Ghana also contracted a company to supply 100,000MT of maize. The Ministry of Food and Agriculture submitted stores receipt advice as evidence of delivery of the 100,000MT of maize worth GH¢771.2 million to the Ministry of Finance for payment, but only 11,900MT were supplied and distributed.

Mr Speaker, it is worth noting that the stores receipt advice was supported by a checklist that was certified by the internal auditor of the Ministry of Food and Agriculture.

Over payment for transportation of grains.

Mr Speaker, under the Farmer Food Relief and Recovery Programme, a transportation company was contracted to transport 134,000 MT of maize and rice to farmers across the country at a contract sum of GH¢115.2 million. Even though the company transported only 35,000MT out of the 134,000MT, which should have costed GH¢30.9 million, the company was paid in cash GH¢50 million.

In addition to this payment, the company was given 7,311MT of rice equivalent to 14,622 bags of 50kg rice, which amounts to GH¢11.7 million in lieu of cash for no work done. This brings total payment to GH¢61.7 million to the transportation company. As a result, the Auditor-General accordingly rejected an amount of GH¢65.2 million that was requested by the Ministry of Food and Agriculture as additional payment to said transport company.

The unfounded teacher trainee arrears.

The Ministry of Education reported unpaid allowances totalling GH¢160 million Ghana cities to teacher trainees under the Ghana Tertiary Education Commission (GTEC). When auditors engaged GTEC, the agency confirmed that as of December 2024, there were no outstanding arrears. Over GH¢159 million would have been lost, but for this audit.

Duplicated entries under the Ministry of Education.

An amount of GH¢6.1 million appeared on the Ministry of Education's BTA schedule at the Comptroller and Accountant General's department, even though the same funds had already been paid by a donor partner. Such entries opened a door for double payments and exposed a dangerous pattern of weak oversight and porous coordination between donor and government financial records.

Bank transfer advices without supporting documents.

Mr Speaker, Auditors identified BTAs totalling GH¢293 million for six MDAs with no documentation. There were no contracts, no IPCs and no record of any executed work.

The breakdown of the unsupported BTAs are as follows:

Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection (MoGCSP) – GH¢241.2 million.

Ministry of Roads and Highways – GH¢26.3 million.

Judicial Service – GH¢18.2 million.

Ministry of Special Initiatives – GH¢3.7 million.

Ministry of Health – GH¢2.4 million; and

Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice (OAGMOJ) – GH¢782,262

Falsified stalls receipt advises intended for misappropriation of public funds.

Mr Speaker, auditors uncovered transactions worth GH¢9.4 million supported by forged stalls receipt advises, Stores Receipt Advices (SRA) that had been used to justify requests for payment for goods that were never delivered.

Ministry of Defence – GH¢4.8 million.

A contract between the Ministry of Defence and a company for vehicles intended for border surveillance and monitoring of the 2024 general election revealed that despite the issuance of SRAs – which is an official document confirming that goods have been received – dated 12th October, 2024, the vehicles were never delivered.

Similarly, the Judicial Service appeared to be caught in a web of falsified SRAs.

2.43 p.m.

While an SRA dated 25th October, 2024 claimed the receipt of 7 Toyota saloon cars, as soon as the audit was initiated, the supplier wrote to the Judicial Service on 10th April, 2025, indicating their inability to supply the said vehicles as scheduled. This shows that fraudulent documents were submitted to the Ministry of Finance for payments, and steps have been taken to avoid the recurrence of this incident.

Mr Speaker, these cases illustrate a disturbing pattern of fraud designed to deprive the people of Ghana of hundreds of millions of cedis of public funds.

Findings on Claims

Recycling of Already Paid IPCs/ Invoices.

Mr Speaker, claims amounting to GH¢4.4 billion, which had already been paid between 2020 and 2024, were

fraudulently resubmitted for payment. These recycled claims originated from the following MDAs:

- Ministry of Roads and Highways - GH¢3.6 billion;
- Ministry of Health - GH¢384.8 million;
- Ministry of Energy - GH¢216.7 million;
- Ministry of Food and Agriculture - GH¢57 million;
- Ministry of Defence - GH¢40.9 million;
- Independent Power Producers - GH¢36.4 million;
- Ministry of Finance - GH¢26.4; and
- Ministry of the Interior, GH¢3.1 million.

Mr Speaker, but for our vigilance, the Ghanaian taxpayer would have lost a colossal GH¢4.4 billion in these recycled claims. One eye-opening finding of this audit was that MDAs did not have sufficient records of what they had contracted, what they had paid, and what was outstanding. Shockingly, the Government of Ghana was at the mercy of contractors and suppliers to determine how much is owed to them.

Mr Speaker, this calls for an urgent review, redesign, and implementation of an appropriate Public Financial

Management (PFM) architecture to manage our public funds.

Duplicated and Overstated Claims

Mr Speaker, auditors identified duplicated and overstated claims by MDAs totaling GH¢1.4 billion. These MDAs include:

- Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, duplicated claims were to the tune of GH¢408.3 million;
- Ministry of Energy duplicated claims were GH¢386.7 million;
- The National Service Scheme alone overstated allowance arrears by GH¢334.5 million;
- Ministry of Roads and Highways duplicated claims of GH¢125.65 million;
- Ministry of Health duplicated claims amounted to GH¢114.2 million; and
- NCCE duplicated claims was GH¢8.8 million.

Expired Contracts Recorded as Fresh Liabilities

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Defence reported GH¢77.1 million as outstanding claims for which IPCs and invoices were issued, although the contract had expired and deliveries were not made.

Overstated Claims

Mr Speaker, according to the auditors, confirmation responses received indicated an overstatement in claims by GH¢161.9 million. These emanated from:

- Department of Urban Roads - GH¢57 million;
- Ministry of Transport - GH¢39.9 million;
- Department of Feeder Roads - GH¢22.46 million;
- Ministry of Food and Agriculture - GH¢20 million;
- Ghana Highways Authority - GH¢17.5 million; and
- Ministry of Foreign Affairs - GH¢2.68 million.

Agenda 111

Mr Speaker, the audit of Agenda 111 projects also revealed that a total amount of US\$7.9 million was paid to 35 contractors as advance mobilisation under the programme. But these contractors have either failed to mobilise to site or the work done is not commensurate with the amount paid. The advance mobilisation guarantees secured by the 35 contractors who received the US\$7.9 million have all expired. The Auditor-General has subsequently issued notices of surcharge to the offending contractors.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, this audit has exposed a rotten system designed to fleece the people of Ghana. It reveals not just lapses in our public financial management architecture, but a pervasive and systemic plunder of the public purse. A culture marked by:

- i. The fabrication of fictitious claims;
- ii. The resubmission of recycled invoices;
- iii. The forgery of stores receipt advice; and
- iv. The treatment of public funds as personal entitlement rather than as public trust.

The President Mahama Administration refuses to accept this rotten system. In fact, we refuse to normalise waste. And we refuse to ask the Ghanaian people to pay for fraud. Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance has formally referred the report of the Auditor-General to the Attorney-General to bring to account those responsible for this rape of the public purse. Those who abused their offices, colluded with contractors, falsified records, or attempted to loot the public purse through the back door will be held to account.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Finance will no longer serve as a rubber stamp for weak controls and falsified claims. Going forward, no payment will be made without full verification, no commitment will be entered into without budgetary allocation, and no officer, regardless of

rank, will be shielded from accountability. This moment marks a decisive break from the past. A reset of public financial management, a declaration that discipline has returned to the centre of fiscal and economic governance.

Mr Speaker, the Ghanaian people demand accountability, and under His Excellency President Mahama's Government, that demand will be met with action. I thank you very much, Mr Speaker, and I seek your leave to lay the Report of the Auditor-General. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Deputy Minister for Finance. Hon Members, I will open the floor for comment, subject to Order 91(3) and (4).

Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah, you have the floor —

Mr Dafeamekpor — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, by way of a guide, we want to pray that we take 3 comments from each Side. [*Uproar*] I am making a proposal, so they should listen to me. If they have a counter-proposal, they should say so.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority leadership, the proposal is to take 3 comments from each Side.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, normally we would have to agree instead of communicating directly

to the Chair. I do not think that is what the Majority Side did. That notwithstanding, I would want to suggest that we take 5 comments plus Leadership, making 6. Because, Mr Speaker, this is an important matter that has just come. We would be happy to talk about it, especially when the Deputy Minister talks about rot in governments. I am sure he would soon see that things are more rotten under the very administration he serves than what he complains of.

So, Mr Speaker, it is good he has brought it on. Let us take it to the cleaners. We are ready for them.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

By Order 91(4), the comments must not exceed 5 minutes. The timekeepers are up there. The floor is now open. Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah.

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah (NPP — Okaikwei Central): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make some few comments on the Statement by the Deputy Minister for Finance.

12:53 p.m.

Mr Speaker, this Statement to Parliament is on the report of the Auditor-General on arrears and payables at the end of 2024. Article 187 of the Constitution of this country establishes the Office of the Auditor-General of Ghana and empowers the Auditor-General of Ghana to look into the books of all Metropolitan, Municipal and

District Assemblies (MMDAs) and institutions of this country. It also gives persons affected by the report of the Auditor-General the opportunity to explain certain things before a formal report of the Auditor-General is laid before the House within six months after each financial year. Mr Speaker, we do not know the basis of this report. Has the Auditor-General given those implicated or mentioned in this report or those officers or the institutions mentioned there under the opportunity to respond and take advantage of the provisions under Article 187(9) which says that:

“A person aggrieved by a disallowance or a surcharge made by the Auditor-General may appeal to the High Court”?

Mr Speaker, I believe the Minister for Finance has rushed into presenting this Statement. There are various officers or institutions of state who had to be invited to answer questions. The National Democratic Congress (NDC) Administration has been in power for a year and a half. They have all the powers of State to invite anyone who has committed any offence to be investigated and brought before any court of competent jurisdiction. Mr Speaker, we rush to this House, make this Statement, implicate people and later go back and find out that they have not committed any offence.

Mr Speaker, let us be careful with the way we handle public officers. There have been so many occasions where reports have been submitted to us, referrals made to the Public Accounts

Committee, the records are sent to them and it shows that they have committed no offence. Mr Speaker, let us be very careful. I am sure the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance is in a rush to satisfy or settle some scores. This is not the forum for this Statement. This is not an appropriate Statement referred to us as a House, as enshrined in the Constitution of this country by the Auditor-General. He is putting the cart before the horse and he should be very careful about this tangent that he is threading.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Kwame Agbodza?

Mr Kwame Governs Agbodza (NDC — Adaklu): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to make a few comments about this very important Statement.

Mr Speaker, this is the right forum to talk about this, and by the time I finish explaining, Colleagues would understand why this is the best forum. Mr Speaker, the Statement talks about contracts. Some of the largest contracts in this country are approved by this House. This House approved even road contracts where we include in the contract that we will buy even mobile phones that the contractor would use on the project. We borrow money to buy mobile phones for the contractor on the project. **[An Hon Member: Ei!]** Yes, you said, *ei!* That is what we have approved. We even pay for the mobile phone to be used by the contractor, approved by this House. Tell me this is

not the best forum. This House approves contracts and say we should pay a contractor US\$29 million as mobilisation, and if we fail to do certain things, the contractor can walk away free with our US\$29 million. Tell me this is not the right forum.

I do not know about your constituency, but in my Constituency, there would be a pregnant woman today who may be struggling to find a health facility to attend. I have constituents today who are looking for potable water to drink and if we as Members of Parliament, write a contract and give away US\$29 million to a contractor and say that when the contractor raises a next certificate and we unable to pay, the contractor can walk away with US\$29 million. Tell me if this is not the right forum to be talking about it. What has this got to do with the Auditor-General? It is Members of Parliament who should do our work diligently. How do we feel about buying a mobile phone for a contractor? I believe these issues are very serious.

Mr Speaker, during the validation process by the Ministry of Finance, it is quite obvious. In fact, I have at the Ministry currently about GH¢500 million claims that when the contractors were asked to show their contracts, they left and did not return. But these contracts were formed at the Ministry, at the agencies. Tell me this is not the right forum so that we who represent the people will do things right. It is not about NDC or the New Patriotic Party (NPP); these moneys are being wasted in our name. It is not about anybody there or

me, but this is the waste that is in the system. When every day, including tomorrow afternoon, Members keep asking me when the contractor who has stopped working in their various constituencies be paid? Tomorrow, I will be asked those questions. Mr Speaker, the Hon Minority Leader should bear with me. Tomorrow afternoon, I would be asked Questions by Colleagues, why is the contractor on their roads not working? I tell you that this same House has approved US\$29 million to be spent on a road project from Savelugu to Walewale, and the contractor walked free. Tell me this is not important. It is very important.

Mr Speaker, I am urging the House, as a Minister. I can guarantee—*[Interruption]*—It is important for Parliament to take our work diligently because I know there may be contracts in Committees and other things. Let us do diligent work so that going forward we avoid these things. We have situations where last week I said we were so reckless in contracting and commitment that almost 90 per cent of road contracts that were awarded in 2024 did not have any commitment authorisation. That day, I said that including the Constituency of the former Minister for Finance, he did not even issue commitment authorisation for roadworks. That is reckless.

Members of Parliament, the buck stops with us. We must do our work diligently. If we say this is not the right forum, I say, this is 100 per cent the right forum to bring this issue. I want us to help the Government make sure that we tighten these things. It does not matter

whether it is NDC or NPP that is the government. These roads were not necessarily sanctioned by politicians, but that is the system we inherited. We are only calling for a reset of the system, and President Mahama is saying that he will reset the system, and I call upon Members to support that system.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Kabiru Mahama, you have the floor.

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Mr Speaker, I would want us to put to bear the matter of fact that whenever the Minister for Roads and Highways is called to contribute to a Statement, he finds ways and means of sneaking tangential matters into the discussion and I want the House to record and put same into the *Hansard* that the Savelugu-Walewale road was a contract awarded in line with the Public Procurement Act of the country, mobilisation was given to that contractor, and if there is anything wrong, these people have 11 months—*[Uproar]*—They have one year to go and recover that money. They should not keep coming to this House and complain about the same thing. Nothing untoward was done in that project, and they know that, but they do it because of politics.

Mr Speaker, let me now come to the Statement. In the year 2017, when the then government handed over to Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo, an audit of the arrears was done. Mr Speaker, GH¢13 billion was audited as arrears and claims on the Government of Ghana.

Then, the current Minister for Finance was Deputy Minister for Finance. Out of the GHC13 billion that was audited, GHC5.5 billion was certified. About GHC5.7 billion was rejected. That constituted 50 per cent of rejected claims.

3:03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, today, the same apostles are coming to tell us that 11 per cent of amount has been rejected and it is news. Only 11 per cent of the GHC68 billion of that has been rejected and that is news. Mr Speaker, 50 per cent of what they presented to the next Government was rejected and the Minister for Finance presented that to this House which is part of the records of this House. And today, they are the apostles of good governance and resetting.

Mr Speaker, as a matter of fact, no one is condoning and supporting any contractor or agency using the resources of the country for personal gain. We, on this particular Side of the aisle, will never support that. But when they present that and package that in the form of propaganda to make a government look bad, we will point it to them that they are being political, untruthful and disingenuous.

Mr Speaker, let me come to that finding. In that particular report in 2017, they stated that the audit reports showed that inflated contracts were one of the problems. The same thing has been found in this Report. Secondly, there were no essential contracts. In fact, there was lack of proper documentation in that

Report and the same thing has been presented today. So, when they present and make it look as if the previous Government did something untoward, Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect, they are not being true to the facts. Because in their tenure, under the Minister for Finance, who was the then Deputy Minister for Finance, superintended over 50 per cent of the claims being fictitious. Why do they come to us as apostles of good governance and resetting agenda to look good?

Mr Speaker, you should scrap the hypocrisy in this House. Let us face the issue of governance with seriousness. When we do that, I am sure governance will be good.

Mr Speaker, let me then come to the issue of the road sector. Under the road sector, they presented a bill of GHC11.2 billion in 2017. Go to the facts. More than half of that were fictitious. They come back today and tell us that there was no good governance? Mr Speaker, let these people bow their heads in shame and let us approach the issue with the seriousness it deserves. No one will ever deceive anyone from this Side about facts and records in this House.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude with a very important point. There is lack of proper record system in the country and everyone takes the opportunity to do as they wish. Once there is no proper record system and one goes to the Ministry and does not have records, they cannot not blame the contractor. As a matter of fact, there is poor record system at the

Minister of Roads and Highways, Ministry of Finance and across every agency in the country. The fact that one does not see the document does not mean that work has not been done. We need to fix that and fix that well.

Mr Speaker, the other issue was that state agencies were involved. All those accusations are in relation to state agencies and no individual has been mentioned. They referred to Ghana Tertiary Education Commission (GTEC) and others. It tells us one story that state agencies would have to be strengthened in order to do their work in a manner that is appropriate and right.

Mr Speaker, finally, the Minister blames and condemns people without even hearing from them. What stops them from inviting people in those agencies to listen to them before they even come? You do not condemn a man before you hear him. It is in line with the basic principle of natural justice. Listen to the man. Let him give you his view before you can condemn him. With these few words, I thank you for the opportunity. Thank you very much. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, let me take Hon Kwakye Ofose.

Minister of State in charge of Government Communications (Mr Felix Kwakye Ofose): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to comment on this Statement. The defensive posture adopted by our Colleagues on the other Side is telltale. Because a reading of the presentation

made by the Deputy Minister for Finance shows clearly that there was a systematic effort to loot the resources of this country. We are not talking about minor clerical errors or minor computational errors in ascertaining how much the State owed to contractors and service providers. We are talking about carefully crafted schemes to fleece the people of Ghana and I am astonished that there are people on the other Side who are even opposed to an exercise to bring this to light. They are saying that this very House that approved and gave authority to the Minister for Finance to engage in this spending should not have oversight when it comes to finding out how those resources were used.

Mr Speaker, this is a special audit commissioned by the Minister for Finance who, during his very first Budget presentation to this House, said that this audit would be conducted. He has finished the audit and brought the Report to this House for consideration so that, at the very least, we may authorise steps to be taken to ensure that they do not recur. And yet, people who superintended the affairs of this country for eight years are opposed to this exercise. It is bad enough that this wanton rape and looting of State resources occurred under them but it is even more shocking that they appear to want to stand in the way of Government as we take steps to correct this.

Mr Speaker, I have just heard my Colleague, Dr Kabiru Mahama, lament the fact that they came to meet similar occurrences in 2017. He has only confirmed that for all eight years they

wasted our time and did nothing to correct problems that they inherited. We are not terribly afflicted by the same bag of lethargy. We intend to correct and reset this country. *[Hear! Hear!]* So, every problem that we meet, we will resolve and one of them is sealing the loopholes that allow for the brazen theft that they superintended in the eight years they were in power.

Mr Speaker, how is it possible for a whole Government to preside over a situation where they claim to have paid GH¢10.5 million to a specific account in a specific bank in this country, yet auditors go to the bank and the bank says, first of all, no such payment has been made and that no such account even exists there? This is brazen theft of public resources and the records of the Republic of Ghana show that this payment has been made. How can anybody be opposed to an effort to correct this? Mr Speaker, how do you award a contract and pay the contractor fully when he has not done work? In which jurisdiction is this acceptable? And how can Members of Parliament who have been elected by their constituent come to this House and oppose efforts to correct this?

Mr Speaker, they had eight years to deal with anything that they found to be problematic when they came to power. When they were in power, they hauled several members of the past administration to court over alleged wrongdoing. Nothing stopped them from dealing with this systematic rape of our resources. But President Mahama and the Minister for Finance are determined

to ensure that not a dime goes to the wrong hands. If you read the Statement that the Deputy Minister presented carefully, he indicated steps that are being taken to ensure that this does not recur. He has also said more importantly that all those responsible for this brazen theft of our resources will be held to account. I hear them say that, “oh, if they have done wrong, hold them to account”. Mr Speaker, this is a jurisdiction where the rule of law applies. You must do it systematically. So, the first step has taken place, which enables us to know what has happened. After that, firm action will be taken against those who are complicit in this crime against the State.

Mr Speaker, it also raises questions about our oversight. It simply means that we have to do more as a House to ensure that the public purse is protected. We just do not need to give budgetary allocations to Ministries, Departments, and Agencies. We must defend and protect the public purse from the sort of rape that the Deputy Minister has highlighted. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Dominic Nitiwul?

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul (NPP — Bimbilla): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to comment briefly on the Statement made by the Deputy Minister for Finance. Mr Speaker, it is very clear to see what is going on. In fact, the Government is under pressure about the cocoa issues. *[Uproar]* This is the third

time that the Minister for Finance is trying to smuggle an item into Parliament to distract public attention. Nothing, let me repeat, nothing will distract our attention from the suffering of the cocoa farmers and from the suffering of Ghanaian farmers. Nothing, not even these concocted stories will distract our attention.

Mr Speaker, in the first Budget of the Minister for Finance, he mentioned this and it was debunked. He came back mid-year, mentioned it and it was debunked. Today, they smuggled this — In fact, they did not even inform our Leadership that they are going to make this Statement.

3:13 p.m.

They smuggled this Statement through because they are under pressure. Nothing will stop us.

Mr Speaker, let me state that they have been in Government for 15 months. The Auditor-General of Ghana has presented his Report for the years 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024 and even that of 2025, which he is presenting in June. If the Auditor-General so believes, that these infractions happened, it should have found its way in his Report and not in yours. This is fictitious—
[Interruption]

Mr Speaker, this is a special Report, which has nothing to do with the Auditor-General's Report; it has nothing to do with the Auditor-General Report. They should show me—Let me give them an example. On the page numbered

10 of the Report, it mentions the Minister for Defence. I was a Minister for Defence. We have not and we never signed any contract to buy vehicles for the purpose of the elections held in 2024; it is not from the Ministry of Defence.

We made a request for vehicles and the nature of it was that, all the contracts of the various agencies were done at the Ministry of National Security. We at Ministry of Defence never did it. They are not telling the people of Ghana the truth.

Secondly, they said there is a contract between the Ministry of Defence and a company; no name or information was given. They said that it was intended for the border surveillance and monitoring of the 2024—Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Defence does not pay on receipts. If he is ever a Minister for Defence, he would realise that we do not pay on receipts. We pay when the Ghana Armed Forces set up a board. The board will review all the documents, conduct inspections, making sure that physically, the items requested and contracted, has arrived and have about 10 board members present, before the Minister is advised. We do not pay the receipts.

The Ghana Armed Forces through the Ministry of Defence does not pay by receipts. So, there is no way that the Ghana Armed Forces or the Ministry of Defence will pay GH¢4.4 million because of receipts. If there is no Board of Acceptance Report, we do not pay. That is the first thing I want them to know.

Mr Speaker, on the page numbered 10, they said that some recycled invoices—We have since not been paying by invoices. We pay through Ghana Integrated Financial Management Systems (GIFMIS). He knows that the Government of Ghana (GoG) since 2020, has not been paying by invoices but by GIFMIS. If you supply something, you put it on GIFMIS and once you have already put something on GIFMIS, it would not accept it again.

They should not do some propaganda piece of audit and come and spring it on Members of Parliament (MPs) because they are hot. They should give answers to the cocoa issues.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan?

Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan (NDC — Tamale North): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this very disturbing and shocking Statement that has been presented ably by the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, first of all, this Statement is properly situated under Standing Order 91 and I quote:

“(1) The Speaker may make a statement on any matter of interest to the House.

(2) A Minister of State may make a statement of government policy, and the statement shall

(a) be limited to facts which are necessary to be made known to the House;”

Mr Speaker, I see no reason why reference is made to the process as outlined in the Constitution with regard to how Auditor-General Report is presented. That is not contested and in question at all. The fact is that, the Minister is making a Statement and sharing facts that this House needs to know.

Mr Speaker, what is disturbing, especially listening to contributions, is that it seems to me that, once again, as Members of the political class, we are missing the point and are claiming this as our problem, which we will turn into a political football. I expected that we were all going to be shocked and scandalised and speak in support of Government's action to fix and rectify these problems. This is because the Minister, in his Statement, did not even accuse any politician, past or present. He simply spoke to facts as contained in the Auditor-General's Report.

Let us not delude ourselves. Every government in this country has either been toppled through a coup or through the ballot box as a result of corruption. Every time the people feel that their leaders are corrupt, they choose a means of getting them out of power. In the Fourth Republic, we have been lucky and have been doing so through the ballot box. It does not mean that if we continue to ignore these challenges, we will always have the opportunity to be replaced through the ballot box. May

God forbid, let us not ever get to a point where the decision will be taken for us to go decades backwards to get our leaders replaced through the barrel of the gun.

Mr Speaker, it should be shocking and scandalous to anybody to hear, for example, there was an attempt for payments to be made—On the page numbered 5, the Deputy Minister makes the report to us, that there were fictitious debts of GHC89.4 million. How did it happen? That the then Minister for Trade and Industry in 2024, submitted a request of GHC89.4 million to the Ministry of Finance to be transferred to five commercial banks as Government contribution to interest payments under the One District One Factory Initiative.

Mr Speaker, and according to the Hon Minister, when auditors contacted these five banks to confirm the liability, every single one of them denied being owed any amount by Government under the said arrangement. How is it any of our Colleagues on the other Side's problem? How is it their problem to want to defend this?

Mr Speaker, let us be very careful. Let us all come together as Members of Parliament who are concerned about the loot that has been going on sometimes in our name as members of the political class and ensure that we support the action that the Minister and this Government is taking, to seal these loopholes and to hold the people responsible. So that we can give assurance to our people to know that at

least, this generation of leaders are different and are committed to preserving the public funds.

Mr Speaker, these are not just figures. When you hear GHC89 million, GHC293 million and others, these are not just figures. These are missed jobs, missed roads, hospitals that are not built and so on. This leads to loss of lives. This creates more unemployment for our youth. So let us not just look at these figures and think that we can reduce them to political ping-pong games.

Let us support the Minister for Finance and this Government to ensure that the people who—*[Hear! Hear!]*—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Mr Kennedy Nyarko Osei (NPP—Akim Swedru): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I am saddened by the kind of comments that are coming from my Colleagues on the other Side. Mr Speaker, this problem has been with this country for years—*[Interruption]*—They should please allow me to speak. When it is their turn, they can also speak.

3:23 p.m.

It has been with this country for years. We are unable to resolve this matter because of the way we have always turned the matter to be partisan and accusing ourselves as politicians each and every day.

Mr Speaker, those who commit this atrocity and these infractions are the technocrats. They are sitting there. They know them. They are still there approving. They are still in the ministries and the agencies. They are still approving for payments. Their names are there. They know them. No politician or Minister sitting here signs a cheque. Which Minister sits here and signs a cheque at the ministry? It is done by the technocrats. Who does the authorisation for those payments? They are there. It is the technocrats but we come here and create the impression that, all politicians here are criminals; we are corrupt, just to score political points and when we go out and the people are chasing us, then we do not know what to do.

Mr Speaker, this is a very dangerous thing that we are doing as the political class. I am all for it, that we need to put measures in place. This is a systemic problem. It is a systemic problem. We put the Ghana Integrated Financial Management Information System (GIFMIS) in place. What was the import of having that system in place? It is to check to ensure that every payment that we make in this country goes through a system. Who is in charge of approving those GIFMIS? Who is in charge? Even in our districts, sometimes when we do not put certain projects in the GIFMIS, there are some officers who will tell us that they would be able to review and correct it for us and they go behind the scenes to put certain things in it. We turn back, come here and blame ourselves. I will support every measure that this Government wants to put in place to correct this. But when we are correcting

it, let us make sure that those people who have been committing these infractions or these criminally-minded activities are brought to book. They are there. We know them. They are at the ministries and the agencies. They are the technocrats. They are the public servants. They are there. Our colleagues in Government work with them and see them all the time. They come to them. They come and confuse them, subdue them to give them blank cheques and they go and work.

Mr Speaker, I think it is time for us as a House to come together and stop the politicisation of this matter, if indeed we are committed, and not for any political reason, to resolve this matter. Let us come together and resolve this matter once and for all. About eight or nine years ago, a government came, conducted the same audit and found those infractions. Today, another government has come and they have also found the same infraction. I am sure when this Government also leaves office and another government comes, they would also conduct another audit and find the same infractions. We would come here and the technocrats would be enjoying. They would be sitting back and enjoying the goodies that they are making out of the kind of politics that we are engaging in.

Mr Speaker, I want to thank you for giving me this opportunity and I want to call the House for us to come together and depoliticise this matter and make sure that we are able to resolve this matter once and for all.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Minister for Energy and Green Transition?

Mr Richard Gyan-Mensah (NDC— Gomoa West): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to comment on the Statement made by the Deputy Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, I must say I am very saddened with the report, especially seeing the whopping sum of money that is deliberately dissipated, or there is an attempt, per the report, to be mismanaged. I think with the sum that we are seeing here, as a House, just as our Colleagues are all recommending, should not be politicised. These numbers we are seeing here today may be huge than what we have always seen in the past, but I think it is about time we looked at how best we would be able to nip this in the bud as a House.

Mr Speaker, I heard one of my Colleagues making a claim that this report is being brought just to take the attention off cocoa prices or whatever, but I think this goes beyond that. With the figures we are seeing here, as a House, we should all be concerned about how we are going to deal with it. My Colleague just mentioned technocrats, but as politicians, at the end of the day, with the sums that are seen here, the technocrats will not be mentioned. That is why the report has been brought to this House for us to deliberate. It should just go beyond the deliberation. If we have to take the necessary legal actions, we recommend that we do that, so that even if the politician is not the one who signs,

they will be the one to approve. Whatever we have to do together to make sure that we do not see these figures again — because we have our students here. When the students see GH¢8 billion as an amount that was supposed to have been paid, but it has been rejected, this GH¢8 billion has a lot that can be done for almost all the secondary schools in Ghana. If we have 800 secondary schools, it means that each secondary school will get no less than GH¢10 million.

Mr Speaker, GH¢8 billion will be able to fix all the roads in the Central Region. My able Senior, Hon Afenyo-Markin's roads are well done, so maybe when they see this GH¢8 billion, they will not be concerned. But because my roads are not done, I am so concerned about this GH¢8 billion that has not been accounted for. So, I am only calling on the House that it should not just be a report that has been brought to us for us to deliberate. We should all see how best we can come together and work with the office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice or the respective Committee to ensure that the law takes its course on all the perpetrators or people who are aligned with this.

I want to thank the Minister for Finance and his Deputy for the good works they are doing, especially saving the nation of this whopping GH¢13 billion, which I believe that once they have saved it, going forward, it can be used to cushion the cocoa farmers whom they are saying that their prices have been reduced. This money can help to support the cocoa farmers. So, if we

really care about the cocoa farmers, let us see how best we can save this sum of money to support them in the future.

Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah, you have the floor.

Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah (NPP—Manhyia South): Mr Speaker, when we first came to this House, one of the first or initial advice that we were given was that we should be careful what we say as politicians, because that has become the basis for the nation to develop mistrust for politicians.

Mr Speaker, it appears that the advice was not taken by the same persons who were giving that advice. I can appreciate why our Colleagues on the other Side of the aisle keep making reference to report, as though what the Deputy Minister read on the floor of this House was a report because they are confusing a report with a Statement. What is up for debate is not the report, but a Statement. It is a Statement by the Minister containing extracts, supposedly extracts —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I did not call for debate on anything.

Mr Awuah: Mr Speaker, comments containing extracts and not the report itself.

Mr Speaker, respectfully, the audit report will contain the management responses. The audit report will contain

responses by persons who were the subject of this audit. The Statement does not. And with what we have, we do not even know whether it is coming from the report. There are no references as to which page of the report it is referring to. It does not contain responses by the persons under reference or the institutions that are subject of this audit. Yet, it has been debated as though it is the report itself. It is being debated as though it is the gospel, but it is not.

3:33 p.m.

This is the reason Ghanaians sit out of this Parliament and think that we cannot be trusted. This is nothing but a propaganda piece. For instance, the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry. It is a matter of record that no payment was made because no disbursement was made by the bank.

Mr Speaker, there will be no disbursement by the Ministry because until payment is made, interest payment is not required. But because of propaganda value, this is being presented to the House as though something has happened. The essence of Article 187 of the Constitution should not be lost on us because of our oversight responsibilities; it is incumbent upon us to ensure that systems are improved to prevent losses to the state. And therefore, historical audit reports will be deductive in this journey. Historical audit report teaches us that it is not in all circumstances that losses are incurred by the state. However, there is the potential for a loss and so we, as a House, should be fashioning out ways to manage the systems in place to prevent a loss.

Mr Speaker, the essence of audit reports is not for propaganda. If one does propaganda, one will be exposed. We thought that they were going to learn from the Attorney-General. Today, they have been embarrassed by their so-called Operation Recover All Loot (ORAL) because it is of no value. The evidence is said to contain garbage, *nwura nkoaa*. They have done the same propaganda for 15 months. Today, they have been exposed by the electricity charges. Electricity tariffs are exposing them for doing nothing in government for the last 15 months. They have been exposed by water tariffs, which, for the last 15 months, they have not been doing anything in government.

Mr Speaker, business owners are suffering. They cannot pay the electricity tariffs. Cocoa farmers are suffering because the Government is struggling to manage the cocoa sector. This is nothing other than propaganda. Their Government so far is government by propaganda, of propaganda, with propaganda, and full of garbage.

Mr Speaker, thanks for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Isaac Adongo, it is now your turn.

Mr Isaac Adongo (NDC — Bolgatanga Central): Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr Speaker, I am very sad, and I want my Colleagues to take a cue from some of the comments that Hon Suhuyini and my Colleague on the other Side

made. What we are doing is that we are shielding criminals in this Chamber. Nobody is saying that a politician has stifled money. They have left office.

Ernst and Young (EY), PricewaterhouseCoopers (PWC), and the Ghana Audit Service now go to review transactions that are supposedly made in their name and the auditor is saying that he could not validate those transactions because, in some instances, the people whom they claim they owe said that they do not owe them. It is rather vindicating them. They should be happy. Mr Speaker, this should tell us that we have to proceed beyond this. And, I would like to make an appeal to you, under Order 262, that this should require further work by this House and that you should set up an Ad Hoc committee to look into this matter and report back to this House.

Mr Speaker, I want to refer to the Minister for Defence. The report says that in the Ghana Integrated Financial Management Information System (GIFMIS), which he claims we should use, it has been logged in the GIFMIS that he signed the contract. It has been logged in the GIFMIS that they issued a goods received note saying that they received vehicles and on the basis of that, they have made a request to the Minister for Finance to pay. When the Minister audited them, they realised that those things do not exist. So, rather than being happy that they found out that people were going to cheat in their name, they are here defending that they did not sign anything. That is exactly what the report is saying. The report is saying there was no such agreement. So, if they say there

is no agreement, that is what the report is saying.

They say they did not, but somebody left in the GIFMIS that they have taken delivery of six vehicles and the report is saying they did not take delivery of six vehicles. The Minister for Finance is saying that they should pay because they did that and the Hon Minister found out that they did not do that. Why should they be the ones fighting this report? Mr Speaker, I am really worried and let me come back to one of the comments that my own Colleague, Hon Patrick Boamah, made, he said that the people who are part of this and have been accused have not been given a hearing. Unless he does not understand an audit. In any audit, by the time the audit is completed, there is a series of meetings that one needs to answer. Even when one is unable to answer, before they exit, there will be a final conference where they will say, having gone through the audit, they require the provision of some evidence.

Before they leave, they ask if there is anything to be told and if they do not, they put it in the report. And capture it in the management letter because the responses were still not adequate. Because of that, it becomes an audit issue. And Hon Patrick is saying, because of that, the person has not been heard? I do not get it. It is simply that people do not understand the audit process. But if one understands the audit process, everybody involved in this meets the auditor. And so the report was laid here. So why are they in a hurry? It is the reason calling on the Speaker to

refer this and the audit report to an Ad Hoc committee to review and come back to this House. And they will find out that we are protecting the civil and public servants who are there doing their own thing in our name. When we come to tell you that this is what they are doing in their name, they now stand here and defend them and own it. I do not know why we are doing this to ourselves. I simply cannot tell why we are.

Somebody left as a Minister for Trade. He did not authorise the payment of any interest to any financial institution, but in the GIFMIS, it has been locked that some people should be paid interest in banks. Auditors are sent there, and the people say that the State does not owe any interest payment. Now the person sits here, and they are defending that they did not make any payment. It is precisely because—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Adongo, your time is up. Yes, Minority Leadership. You are speaking for 15 minutes.

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, the Deputy Minister for Finance, in a Statement titled “The Report of the Auditor General on Arrears and Payable Assets End 2024” indicated at paragraph 48, page 14 of his Statement, “Mr Speaker, this audit has exposed a rotten system designed to fleece the people of Ghana”.

Mr Speaker, the entirety of the Statement contradicts this particular paragraph of the Statement.

3:43 p.m.

For me, it appears that the Minister was here purposely to create a headline rather than to put together an important national matter for Parliament to discuss.

Mr Speaker, I have listened to Hon Suhuyini. I have also listened to my own Colleague, with whom I share *esprit de corps*, Hon Kwame Govers Agbodza; my own Colleague, Hon Kennedy Osei Nyarko, we came to this Chamber together and not least, Hon Adongo.

Mr Speaker, I have come to one single conclusion from all their submissions that we must fix a system. But, if a Deputy Minister mounts the podium in this Chamber, here our podium is the Despatch Box, a very important platform and includes this in a Statement, obviously nobody will take him seriously. The conclusion will be that he is here on a partisan political agenda with no consequence but to please a certain gallery of vulnerable Ghanaians, and that we want to stop him in his tracks.

Mr Speaker, the Report, of which he has graciously served me a copy, says on the page numbered (i), signed by the Auditor-General himself, paragraph 3 and 4, with your indulgence, I quote “(3) The audit resulted in savings of some GH¢21 billion...” In other words, what the State would have paid but for this audit, there are some savings, which is good. Then, it goes further to say that “...some GH¢115 million would have to be justified.”

Mr Speaker, the Auditor-General makes an observation which I think is critical for my respected Friend, Mr Agbodza. We also noted instances of non-performance by contractors and unaccounted government stores. “We have made recommendations to address the irregularities identified in the Report”; that is what the Auditor-General is saying.

Mr Speaker, somewhere in 2014, I was privileged to have been part of those who were in this Chamber. Mr Kennedy Agyapong, in a similar debate on an audit report, raised the issue of systems and policies, not NDC or NPP, and it became a new term that all of us across the aisle use, and now when we see one another, we say “systems,” and we respond “policies.” This is not about NDC or NPP, that was Mr Kennedy Agyapong right here in 2014. So, when I listened to Mr Agbodza, and listened to Mr Suhuyini, and again listened to my Colleague here, I felt that indeed, the Minister had lost the plot.

Mr Speaker, we are just calm and watching them, not because we do not know. If they are talking about rot, and are saying that a system has been designed to fleece the people, they have a lot —[*Interruption*]— Listen, I did not apologise to Hon Muntaka because I made an allegation against him. No, if they are interested in that, we will go there. So, please, we are talking about a serious matter.

The Hon Minister for Health knows how much I respect him. He should please stay away from this matter, or else

he will hear what he does not want to hear. I am saying that we know how, even with the current recruitment system, Ghanaian youths are being ripped off by the very system because they have to pay and pay.

Mr Speaker, must we label an individual as being corrupt because there is a system that is not functioning and is going against the citizens?

Mr Speaker, I once served as the Chairperson of the Road Fund. I am happy to say that Colleagues on both Sides of the aisle were able to point out how people present the same certificate and manipulate the system for the same payment, and there was a call on the agency to introduce an artificial intelligence (AI) powered software that would detect these things.

Mr Speaker, I hold the humble view that as political leaders, the time has come for us to sit around the table and fix the system. I will be the first to support that. But if he now wants to reduce it to some partisan point scoring, I am sorry, I would not support it because they were in office some years back, like Hon Kabiru referred to. When NPP assumed office in 2017, a similar audit was done, and they know the story; I would not repeat it. But we know that time and again, we all get confronted with system failures. Can we sit together and fix it? I will not put the blame on anybody, but I think that we need to fix the system.

Mr Speaker, if we look at this audit, the Auditor-General is referring to Article 187(8), in fact, there is a

constitutional issue here. Article 187(8) provides, Mr Speaker, with your leave, I read:

“Paragraphs (a) of clause (7) of this article shall not preclude the President, acting in accordance with the advice of the Council of State, from requesting the Auditor-General in the public interest to audit at any particular time the account of any said body or organisation as referred to in clause (2) of this article.”

So, there is nothing wrong if the President requests a special audit; however, where is the Council of State's advice?

Mr Speaker, we have had the opportunity of seeing the directive of the Minister for Finance to the Auditor-General, as contained in whatever directive we received from the President and no reference was made to the Council of State. I challenge the Government that if indeed the Council of State advised in accordance with the Constitution.

Mr Speaker, fortunately, we have a Presiding Officer now who believes in the text of the Constitution and does not depart from the language of the Constitution. So, where is the advice of the Council of State? So, everything they have done here becomes otiose; however, on the basis of national interest, on the basis of prudence, we still hold a view that this must be worked upon.

Mr Speaker, we have our Public Accounts Committee. I do not mind if the referral goes to the Public Accounts Committee. Mr Speaker, what are they afraid of? We need the Public Accounts Committee to go into this matter. Mr Speaker, nobody should attempt to invite you to set up a certain Ad-hoc Committee. We have our own regular Committees that have been established and there is no exceptional situation. The Constitution is clear that when the Auditor-General is done with his work, the referral will be made to the appropriate Committee of Parliament, which is Public Accounts Committee; it is there.

3:52 p.m.

They should refer all the agencies that they claim did anything wrong; they are free to invite those agencies to answer. In any event, the good news is that all previous political appointees are still available. [**Mr Agbodza:** No! Where is Ken?] Mr Speaker, they are available to answer for any matter that has been referred to in this Report. [*Interruption*]

Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader should know that when his Backbench does this and he is also speaking, similar things can be done. If Mr Speaker does not see, it is fine, we have seen. All previous government appointees are in this country. [*Uproar*] Yes, they are here. Mr Speaker, if there is any need to invite anybody, they know what to do. They should follow the law.

Mr Speaker, this morning when we came to Parliament and the understanding was that we were going to start at 12 noon, we were clear in our minds what we were going to do. We expected the Minister for Finance to come here and brief the House on the cocoa matters. Today, the Deputy Minister has been sent to come and brief this House on this, a thing that we already know. [*Uproar*] We know? They have said it over and over again. This is not the first time; we know. They have been saying this over and over again. As Hon Nitiwul said, it is because they are “hot”.

Let me tell them, they promised to create jobs for the youth; they need their jobs. The cocoa money, they are supposed to pay the cocoa farmer, yet they have refused to pay the cocoa farmer. They have increased electricity tariffs by almost 30 per cent. It is hitting households. They were supposed to create jobs; they are not doing so. Where is their 24-Hour Economy? Where is their one job, three shifts?

Mr Speaker, they cannot even take care of their Backbench. They cannot take care of their the 189. Instead of designing policies to help their MPs who are struggling, they are not paying attention to that. Only a few of them are enjoying it. Even Mr Speaker sitting there, how are they resourcing his Constituency so that he can create jobs? That should be their interest and not to come here and then start their propaganda.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, take me out of your comments.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Yes, Mr Speaker, but your Constituency is one of the constituencies that need to be supported. The Deputy Minister for Finance must come here and do the proper thing. His own constituents who are cocoa farmers, he should support them and stop the propaganda.

Mr Speaker, that said, I would want to rest my case, and I hope that next time he will come here and do the needful.

Thank you so much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, before giving the floor to the Majority Leader, let me acknowledge the presence of students from Bisease Senior High School, led by Francis Afari-Sackey, Headmaster. They are from Ajumako/Enyan/Essiam. They are 93 in number.

Hon Member, on your behalf, I welcome them to the Parliament of Ghana, and I urge them to have a fruitful visit. You may resume your seats.

[Students from Bisease Senior High School were acknowledged]

It is now the turn of the Majority Leader and Leader of Government Business. You have the floor.

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, let me join Colleagues to thank the Minister for

Finance for making this Statement and briefing the House on the outcome of the special audit that was conducted into arrears and payables. Mr Speaker, it is part of our record that the Minister last year did indicate that he was holding on to paying some claims because he wanted to conduct a special forensic audit to validate the payments. Indeed, in this Chamber, on several occasions, the Minority Leader had occasion to demand that contractors be paid, and the Minister for Finance responded that he was holding on to the payment because he wanted to verify. So, Mr Speaker, after the verification, the Minister owes it to this House to come and report to us the outcome of the verification. But more importantly, this is not a verification done by the Minister himself or the Ministry, it is an exercise undertaken by the Auditor-General, supported by consultants that they engaged. We all know that by law, the Auditor-General can engage private consultants to assist in carrying out audit exercises.

Mr Speaker, when the Auditor-General audits State institutions, agencies, and public corporations, the normal thing to do is to present the audit to Parliament. The reason is that we as parliamentarians superintend over all these agencies, and we budget for the agencies. So, we should be interested in knowing how they utilise their finances. We represent the people whose lives can be made better if the funds are used judiciously. I heard the Minority Leader say that special provision should be made for Mr Speaker so that Mr Speaker can manage his constituency better. What do we use to make the special

provision? Resources. So, if Mr Speaker authorises resources to agencies and they are wasteful in the use of the resources, with what is the Minister for Finance going to make special provision for every single Member of Parliament here to fix the roads in their constituencies, fix the electricity in their constituencies, fix the broken water systems in their constituencies and deal with the broken schools in their constituencies? Resources. So, we must be interested in how the resources are used. And when this Government decides that we are going to pay special attention to this; it is not political witch-hunting.

I regret that throughout this comment, I have heard Hon Colleagues try to create the impression that politicians are not responsible and that it is rather the technocrats and the bureaucrats. That is not true. Politicians are ultimately responsible. We are ultimately responsible. We are responsible for our ministry and the agencies under our supervision. If there is corruption, if there is waste, it is our responsibility to ensure that those who are engaged in such acts are held to account.

We sit here as parliamentarians and pass the laws, we sit here and approve the Budgets, and we are the ones that the Auditor-General reports to. So, when there is malfeasance, it is our responsibility to ensure that it is corrected. That people are punished.

So, Mr Speaker, this Report that has been presented to us is a very serious indictment of events that occurred in the

past four years. I was in this Chamber when the then Minister for Food and Agriculture came here and told us that there was a dry spell in the north of Ghana, and that we needed to buy food. Their budget was humongous. We grudgingly approved it because we were very sure that there was no way that these food items would arrive at a time when the communities would need it. So, we approved the amount.

4:03 p.m.

Today, we are told that some contractors who took the contracts for 35,000 metric tonnes ended up supplying barely 10,000 metric tonnes and they were paid.

Mr Speaker, the point I am making is this, that we in this House cannot gloss over those matters. If there is an audit report that indicts anybody, without fear or favour, let us hold that person to account. This Government, under His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, is determined to root out corruption. Whether it is corruption by the public servants, the bureaucrats, the civil servants, or even by politicians, let us deal with it decisively. I agree with the Minority Leader that we have heard this so many times. This is why this should be the last time we are hearing it. It will be the last time that we are hearing it because we will set up a Special Committee, and that Committee will look into everything that has been reported on by the Auditor-General.

We will invite all the parties who are involved. We will verify everything that the Auditor-General has discovered, and

this Parliament will make sure that everybody who is indicted in this audit report is held accountable. That has to happen. I do not understand how they can be defensive of a report like this. Indeed, it should excite their curiosity. They should want to know more, and want us to go into it to establish that, indeed, this happened, and it happened in the Republic of Ghana, so that we can fix it and let this Parliament go down in history as a Parliament that stood firmly and fixed the rot in the system.

We must encourage the Minister for Finance. We should not politicise it. How can the Minority Leader get up and say that this Report is being presented because we have a problem with cocoa pricing in the country? How could he ever say that? This is a report that was mentioned in 2025 by the Minister for Finance that he was undertaking. The Report is ready, the Deputy-Minister has presented it, and they are saying that it is because of cocoa prices? Is the price of cocoa a problem only in Ghana? We asked them to go next door to Côte d'Ivoire, so that they will find out if the cocoa crisis is only in Ghana. It is a global affair. Prices have slumped; therefore, countries must adjust to their promises. They should go all over the world and check the prices. This Report could not have been presented to divert attention from the issues of cocoa farmers.

Indeed, Mr Speaker, the incapacity of the economy to support cocoa farmers is because of the massive looting that occurred according to the Auditor-

General's report. Billions of Ghana cedis cannot be accounted for. How much do we need to pay the cocoa farmers in the face of billions of Ghana cedis that cannot be accounted for?

Indeed, looking into how our moneys were squandered is a responsibility that we owe to the cocoa farmer, because that money came from the sweat of cocoa farmers. When they sweat and we sell the cocoa and we receive the proceeds and we squander it in these wasteful manners, we do a great disservice to the cocoa farmers. So, anybody who pretends to be concerned about cocoa farmers must be concerned about how their money is used.

Mr Speaker, I will support the call on this Parliament to set up a Special Committee pursuant to Order 262 of our Standing Orders. I can understand why they are protesting that a Special Committee should not be set up and that it should be referred to the Public Accounts Committee. We will not accept that because their Side chairs the Public Accounts Committee. We will not accept that. It is a special audit. The normal audit reports come and they are referred to the Public Accounts Committee. So, when there is a special audit and a report presented to this House, this House reserves the right to set up a Special Committee to look into it and to report back to us.

How can we refer this matter to a Committee chaired by the NPP when everything that is spoken about here in this Report occurred during the tenure of the NPP? How can we credibly refer this

matter to a Committee chaired by the NPP in this House? Mr Speaker, it will not be credible. We are looking into matters bordering on the activities of the Minister of Finance under the NPP. The Chairperson of the Public Accounts Committee was the Minister of State at the Ministry of Finance, so many of these things occurred during her tenure as Deputy Minister. I am not saying she is responsible, but it occurred during her tenure as Deputy Minister. How can we refer the investigation of such a matter to the same person?

Mr Speaker, this will not wash. The public will not even take us seriously if they see the current Chairperson of the Public Accounts Committee sitting to look into matters that she superintended over. There is a very good case for setting up a Special Committee to look into this audit report and to probe further, invite the parties, verify the things that we see, and this Parliament has the authority to recommend severe punishments. We can recommend prosecutions and we can ask the Auditor-General to take certain actions against those who are found culpable.

Mr Speaker, unless we begin to take these kinds of situations seriously, we will drive our country down the ditch. We can work hard, but if we do not punish for wrongdoing, those who will take over from us will not feel a responsibility to also be accountable. When we take on what happened yesterday, we are guarding against it happening again today. Why? We are in Government. The resources of the state are in our hands now, we control the

institutions, so why do we not just keep quiet and exploit the same loopholes and dysfunctional systems and also enrich ourselves? Why do we not do that? Why?

Mr Speaker, the reason we will not do that is because we have a country to fix. If we do not take on those who conducted themselves so abysmally yesterday in the management of the public finances, we will lose the moral authority to take on those who are in charge today. And if those who are in charge today are holding wide open the books so that we can all learn the wrongs in the society—

4:13 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am not making further comment, but the Majority Leader has introduced a very strange matter that if I do not comment on, a certain precedent will be introduced and that will not inure to the benefit of —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, the Chair is capable of dealing with the matter.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I therefore rest my case.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is a Statement made by the Deputy Minister for Finance, under Standing Order 91. Comments have been taken following the Statement. Now, part of the comments makes reference to Order 262, requesting that we form a Special or Ad hoc Committee to look into the matter. It is important as a House

to look at Standing Order 262. With your permission, I read:

“(1) The House may, by Motion, appoint a Special or an Ad Hoc Committee to

(a) investigate any matter of public importance; and

(b) consider any Bill or matter that is not within the jurisdiction of any of the Standing or Select Committees.”

Now, this is not a Motion; it is a Statement by the Minister, with comments by Members of the House. Others' comments were to the effect that the matter be referred to the Public Accounts Committee to investigate and report. There was also a comment to the effect that the Public Accounts Committee is chaired by the opposition, whose tenure of office the incident took place. Hon Members, we can look at Standing Order 229 (4), which indicates clearly that if the matter refers to the tenure of office of the Chairperson of the Committee, then the Chairperson can recuse himself or herself and allow other Members of the Committee to look into the matter and report to the House.

Hon Members, on this note, I will refer the matter to —

Mr Ayariga — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I believe that because I was timed out by the timekeepers, my last set of sentences related to a Motion. After I had concluded my comment, I followed with a Motion, because I know that Order 262 clearly says that we must come by Motion. So, I concluded by moving a Motion that this House sets up a committee pursuant to Order 262 so that we will look at it.

Mr Speaker, because we were timed out, it definitely is not part of the records of the House. But consider that, because it is not just a question of the Chairperson recusing herself, but also, Mr Speaker, the various years audits have been done by the Public Accounts Committee. The audit Reports of 2021, 2022, and 2023, have already gone to the Public Accounts Committee and they have worked on them. So, when they have worked on a special area and this is a special one, because it is a special audit report, let us set up a Special Committee —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you know in Standing Order 101, clearly, there must be a notice of a Motion. Hon Members, to continue, Standing Order 229 (4) reads:

“(4) Where a matter for consideration before the Committee relates to the period of administration of the Party of the Chairperson of the Committee, the Ranking Member of the Committee shall be the chairperson for the consideration of that matter.”

That is what Order 229(4) is saying. So accordingly, I will refer the matter to the Public Accounts Committee to investigate and report to the House within three weeks.

Hon Members, let me read a message from the Speaker.

FORMAL COMMUNICATION BY THE SPEAKER

Goodwill Message on the Commemoration of International Women's Day, 2026

Mr First Deputy Speaker (Mr Bernard Ahiafor) *on behalf of The Speaker:* In my capacity as the Speaker of Parliament of Ghana and Chairperson of the Conference of Speakers of Presidents of Africa Legislature (CoSPAL), I join my Colleagues across our Continent to celebrate our women in legislature as we commemorate International Women's Day today, 8th March, 2026. In Africa, our Parliaments carry a profound responsibility to represent the full diversity of our citizens and to preserve the credibility of democratic governance. The strength of our legislative institutions, therefore, depends on how inclusive our structures and leadership are. Experience over time has confirmed that when women participate meaningfully in legislative leadership, Parliaments become more effective in law-making, more efficient in oversight and more responsive to the needs of citizens.

Women's leadership strengthens deliberations, broadens policy priorities

and enhances public trust in our institutions. As parliamentary Leaders, we must recognise that expanding leadership opportunities for women is not an act of charity; it is an investment in institutional performance and democratic legitimacy.

4:23 p.m.

Opening spaces and creating opportunities for women benefits our democracies in terms of stability, legitimacy, and stronger policy outcomes.

This is why CoSPAL is currently pursuing two important continental initiatives: Firstly, in collaboration with *ElectHer*, we are advancing the Women's Representation in African Parliament Project (WRAP), to promote data-driven engagement and peer learning to expand women's presence and influence within our legislatures. Secondly, in collaboration with the Policy Innovation Centre, CoSPAL is promoting the Gender Legislative Agenda to encourage institutional reforms that support women's access and participation in the activities of legislatures across the continent.

On this International Women's Day, we reaffirm our collective commitments as African parliamentary leaders towards building representative, credible, and responsive institutions that recognise and support women's leadership.

I wish all women involved in legislative work across the continent a happy International Women's Day.

Hon Members, thank you for the opportunity.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we have two more important Statements; one from the Minister for Health. *[Interruption]* We have advertised Statements, and I am saying that we have two more Statements: one from the Minister for Health, and another advertised Statement. Then we will take the rest of the Statements.

Mr Speaker, may I pray that we vary the order of Business to take Motion numbered 10, and permit the Hon Minister for Transport to lay the Paper.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The application is to do presentation of Papers.

Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, this is not a one-party Parliament that the Majority acts on its own whims and caprices. We are here in Leadership and Members have been sitting here waiting to have their bite on the Message on the State of the Nation. It looks like they are not interested in their own Message on the State of the Nation. They are not interested. So, the prime time that we are supposed to debate this Message on the State of the Nation, they do not want us to take it. Out of the blue, they keep announcing that

we take a Ministerial Statement. Why? We just took a Ministerial Statement, so defective, not anchored on facts, so partisan. Then they come back with a Ministerial Statement.

Mr Speaker, our Members have been waiting to debate. If their Side is not ready, we are ready. Let us have our bite. This business of making an application, especially for Members who only come here when they have Business, they know themselves. They come to heckle, and when they get their way, they leave. Mr Speaker, we will not accept it. At least, he should engage his Colleague here. The practice where the Majority Chief Whip would just get up and announce the varying of Business, Mr Speaker, we will not accept it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, you are not speaking to the application before us.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, that is exactly what I am doing.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The application is to have Papers presented.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we engage in such circumstances. What we know is that we are supposed to take the debate. The Minister for Transport is a Member of this House. He should wait patiently till we finish the debate. Mr Speaker, maybe they are not interested. If they believe in what the President told us, let us get it on the Floor. Let us debate it. They are waiting for people to close; it is 5:00 p.m. They want the debate around 7:00 or 8:00 p.m., when Ghanaians have slept.

Mr Speaker, when many people are going to bed, that is the time they want and we know that trick. It is an old card they are playing. Let us discuss the message of the President at prime time.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I intend to vary the order of Business. At the commencement of Public Business, presentation of Papers, item numbered 10, which is presentation and First Reading of Bill.

Hon Minister for Transport?

BILL — FIRST READINIG

Maritime and Related Offences Bill, 2026

AN ACT to prohibit piracy, robbery at sea and other maritime-related offences give effect to the provisions of the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea in respect of piracy and the International Convention for the Suppression of Unlawful Acts against the Safety of Maritime Navigation, 1988 and related protocols and provide for related matters.

*Presented by the Minister for Transport (Mr Joseph Nikpe Bukari).
Read the First time; referred to the Committee on Roads and Transportation.*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, the rule is clear that upon the request of a Member, the Minister

who laid the Paper will be required to give a short explanatory memorandum to the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister, you are to provide a short explanation.

Minister for Transport (Mr Joseph Nikpe Bukari): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the Maritime and Related Offences Bill, 2026 seeks to prohibit piracy and also to prohibit robbery at sea and other maritime-related unlawful activities that occur in the maritime sector.

Mr Speaker, we are blessed to have the coast or the sea and as such we are serving a lot of the West African countries, being in the centre of the sub-region. We need to have laws that will be able to provide for the safety, navigation and security on our seas and as such we are here with this Bill so that we can provide adequately for the safety at sea and also prevent other unlawful activities that occur at sea.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity for me to lay this Bill today.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much, Hon Minister for Transport.

Yes, Hon Minority Leader, that is his short explanation.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, this is the House of Parliament. The Minister should take the House seriously

with a Ministerial Statement. Mr Speaker, we will not accept extempore—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, with the exercise that we engage in, under what Order are you doing what you are doing?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, first of all, I want to understand your question. Mr Speaker, you mean as I am requesting for—

4:33 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: A Bill has been presented and you applied the rule rightly that the Minister should give a short explanation. The Minister has given the short explanation and before the referral, you got up and started speaking. That is why I am asking which rules of the House support what you are doing.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, I got up invoking your inherent powers as Speaker which is discretionary. Mr Speaker, your inherent powers as a presiding officer is only discretionary. I want your leave to rise under your inherent powers. If that is granted, I will proceed. If that is not granted, Mr Speaker, I have to resume my seat.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, that is not granted.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well. Mr Speaker, that is fine.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members—

Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I, on behalf of the Majority Leader, pray that we go back to Statements that is the item numbered 8 and take a commemorative Statement from the Minister responsible for Health. It is on World Kidney Day, such an important day so, we will take a short Statement from him and then we can deal with the outstanding matters in terms of the Message on the State of the Nation debate. Mr Speaker, I humbly pray.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is the request for the House.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I do not know whether the Majority Chief Whip wants to depart from an unsoiled practice of this House. Mr Speaker, he has been in Minority before and he knows the value inherent in engagement. He cannot just get up because you are avant-garde of Government business just announce applications. Mr Speaker, if that is going to be his approach, we then would have a difficult time ahead of us. We are sitting right here, his Colleague, the Deputy Minority Whip is here—at least engage him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, is it not the case that Statements are admitted by the Speakers?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, can you hear me? Mr Speaker, do not interject me with questions as if I do not know the rules. That is not the import of my submission. Mr Speaker, you and I know that at the Frontbench, we pre-agree on what to do. You know it! He cannot deny the fact that, we are completely unaware of what he is doing now. Our Colleagues have been seated. He knows that we have been prepared for the debate and then all of a sudden, he says that we have a ministerial Statement which is commemorative. It is only fair that he lets us know. We do not even have a copy of that so-called ministerial commemorative Statement. Mr Speaker, we sit here—if that is a new practice because they are in Majority, set the precedent. We will talk no more.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, first of all, it is most inaccurate for the Minority Leader to suggest that I did not engage. We had a discussion at Conclave but he was not there. We agreed that we would take Statements and before today's Conclave, it was contained in the Business Statement adopted for this week. Please! *[Interruption]* That Ministers of State may make Statements. They have been put on notice. His attitude is that I should engage them then they can say no. And when they say no, the business should not be taken. It is unacceptable. Mr Speaker, we have advertised Statements. But with the Ministers of State, when they have major Statements to make, we have to take them. So, the suggestion that it is a new approach for me is completely false.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us all realise the fact that somebody is in charge of the Business of

the House, we have a Leader of Government Business. So, if the Leader of Government Business is making a suggestion, why do we say no? A business that has been discussed at Conclave.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, with all due deference to you. I have always believed that the essence of Conclave is to engage on matters of this nature.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes.

Mr Shaib: But we had Conclave this morning and there was no indication that there was even going to be any form of Statement from the Deputy Minister for Finance, let alone the Minister for Health.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: How come I received those instructions?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, so I am giving you the facts of this morning's Conclave. There was none. My senior Members have been well prepared to deal with the Message on the State of the Nation. Hon Patrick Boamah has been here since morning just because he is going to have his bite of the debate since morning. There has not been any conversation. So Mr Speaker, let us not come and sit here and present a different picture. There has not been any conversation on two Statements, one which is commemorative and the other which is propaganda. No! Mr Speaker, so please, I believe that the essence of going to Conclave is to come at *ad idem* that these are the things we are discussing. And even today, we also had

wind that there is going to be a programme so there was a possibility of even closing earlier. Why all this? They are supposed to have 16 Members to have a bite on today's debate and we are supposed to have eight. We would do 10 minutes and they would do five minutes and if you add all of that, it would be about three hours. When will we finish, Mr Speaker?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I believe that the back and forth will eat away more time. So let me urge you for us to proceed. Because it is a commemorative Statement, I believe that there should be a way of getting the *Hansard* to capture the entirety of the Statement and within five minutes, he can present it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: How many people are commenting?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we can limit it to one from each Side and then leadership will conclude. He can present the Statement in five minutes.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Minister for Health, you have the floor.

STATEMENT

Commemoration of World Kidney Day, 2026

Minister for Health (Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh) (MP): Mr Speaker, I rise today to draw the attention of this

Hon House to the global commemoration of World Kidney Day 2026, observed under the theme, "Kidney Health for All – Caring for People, Protecting the Environment."

World Kidney Day is an important occasion for raising awareness about kidney disease, promoting early detection and strengthening national responses to the growing burden of kidney-related illnesses.

Mr Speaker, kidney disease has emerged as a significant public health concern globally and increasingly within Ghana. Chronic Kidney Disease, often described as a silent condition, progresses gradually and frequently remain undetected until it reaches advanced stages. As a result, many patients report late to the health facilities when treatment becomes more difficult, more expensive and less effective.

In Ghana, the situation is deeply concerning. Current estimates for 2025 place the overall prevalence of Chronic Kidney Disease at between 13 and 19 per cent of the population, representing an average of about 4 million people. This is a significant burden by any measure.

Particularly troubling is the fact that the disease is increasingly affecting younger and economically productive persons, with the average age of patients requiring dialysis estimated at 46 years.

4:43 p.m.

These studies indicate that the highest frequency of renal patients falls

within the 46 to 55 age group, representing 19.24 per cent, followed closely by the 36 to 45 age group at 18.96 percent, and the 26 to 35 age group at 16.57 per cent. This means that kidney disease is not only affecting older populations, but is also imposing a serious burden on younger adults in their most productive years. The data also show that males are more commonly affected, constituting between 57.57 per cent and 65.6 per cent of reported cases. At the same time, the incidence of Chronic Kidney Disease appears to be broadly similar in both urban and rural Ghana, with estimates of 12.3 per cent in urban areas and 12.5 per cent in rural areas. This clearly demonstrates that kidney disease is not confined to one geographic or socioeconomic setting. It is a national health challenge.

Mr Speaker, the burden of kidney disease in Ghana is driven largely by non-communicable diseases such as hypertension and diabetes, unhealthy lifestyles, delayed health-seeking behaviour, misuse of certain medications, and exposure to environmental hazards.

One matter of particular concern to us as a country is the effect of environmental degradation on kidney health. Illegal mining, popularly known as *galamsey*, is releasing harmful toxins into our water bodies and the surrounding environment, and this is contributing to the rise in kidney-related problems in many mining communities. This makes the issue not only an environmental and economic matter, but

also a serious public health concern. Protecting our water bodies is therefore not only about preserving the environment; it is also about protecting the health and lives of our people.

Mr Speaker, these realities remind us that kidney health is not only a clinical issue, but also a development, environmental, and public health challenge. The Government of Ghana, through the Ministry of Health and its agencies, is therefore adopting a comprehensive approach to address kidney disease through prevention, early detection, improved access to treatment, and long-term policy reform.

First, the Government is placing strong emphasis on prevention and early detection through strengthened primary healthcare. Through our ongoing efforts to expand and strengthen primary healthcare services, greater attention is being given to community-level health promotion, routine screening for hypertension and diabetes, and public education on healthy lifestyles. These interventions are critical because early identification of risk factors significantly reduces the likelihood of progression to severe kidney failure.

Our Free Primary Health Care initiative is therefore a key pillar in the national response to kidney disease. By expanding access to preventive services, strengthening early diagnosis at the community and district levels, and reducing barriers to first-contact care, we aim to identify individuals at risk earlier and prevent avoidable complications.

Mr Speaker, while prevention remains central, the Government is equally mindful of the urgent needs of patients who are already living with kidney failure and require specialised care. One of the most pressing challenges faced by such patients is the high cost of dialysis treatment. Dialysis remains a life-sustaining intervention, yet many Ghanaian families struggle to meet the cost of regular treatment.

In recognition of this challenge, the Government has introduced MahamaCares, an intervention designed to strengthen financial protection for patients living with chronic conditions, including those who require dialysis. Through this initiative, the Government is putting in place mechanisms to ensure that vulnerable patients are able to access lifesaving treatment with greater financial support and dignity.

In addition, to improve the availability of dialysis services across the country, the Ministry of Health is partnering with the private sector to expand dialysis service delivery nationwide. These partnerships are intended to help bridge infrastructure gaps, bring services closer to patients, and strengthen national capacity to respond to kidney failure.

Mr Speaker, it is important to note that while dialysis is essential in sustaining life, it is often not the most definitive long-term solution for many patients with end-stage kidney disease. Organ transplantation remains the most effective long-term treatment option. It is therefore worth informing this

honourable House that the Ministry of Health is currently finalising the Organ Transplant Bill for submission to Parliament. This proposed legislation will establish the legal and regulatory framework necessary to guide safe, ethical and well-regulated organ transplantation services in Ghana, while ensuring the protection of donors and recipients alike.

Mr Speaker, the fight against kidney disease requires a collective national effort. The Government, Parliament, healthcare professionals, civil society, traditional leaders, the private sector, and the public must all work together to promote healthy lifestyles, encourage early screening, protect our environment, and support those living with kidney disease.

As we commemorate World Kidney Day 2026, I wish to call on all Ghanaians to prioritise kidney health by adopting healthy lifestyles, seeking regular medical screening, and joining the national effort to protect our water bodies and end harmful practices such as *galamsey* that endanger both our environment and our health.

Mr Speaker, on behalf of the Ministry of Health and the Government of Ghana, I reaffirm our commitment to strengthening prevention, expanding access to care, supporting patients in need, and building a more resilient health system capable of addressing kidney disease and other non-communicable conditions.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is the Statement by the Minister for Health. It is now time for comments.

Yes, Hon Titus Beyuo?

Prof Titus Kofi Beyuo (NDC — Lambussie): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this Statement. Let me thank the Hon Minister for Health for bringing this important matter to the fore for discussion. It is important that we celebrate World Kidney Day. The theme for this year's celebration, which also captures protecting the environment, is worthy of note.

In Ghana, mentioning the environment should tell us the impact of *galamsey* on the prevalence of kidney diseases. Because of time limitations, I pray that if we are looking at preventing and reducing the prevalence of kidney diseases, we must tackle the menace of *galamsey*. The heavy metal poisoning of our water and food has an impact on kidney diseases.

Mr Speaker, as mentioned by the Hon Minister, the prevalence of kidney diseases in the country is between 13 to 19 per cent. About 300,000 people are estimated to be living with what we call end-stage renal disease. End-stage renal disease happens when one has lost about 90 per cent of the kidney function. The kidney is one of the most merciful organs. It does not cause a lot of trouble until it significantly loses its function. So one needs to lose 90 per cent of the function of the kidney to get to the point

of needing dialysis or renal transplant. This gives us enough room for intervention. If we can screen early and identify it, we can prevent ourselves from getting to that level.

The leading causes in Ghana are hypertension, diabetes, unregulated consumption of pain medications, and the consumption of non-scientifically tested herbal medications. If we can minimise this, then we can decrease the prevalence of chronic kidney disease, and for that matter, the requirement for dialysis.

Mr Speaker, I would therefore ask that we emphasise prevention, because the treatment is expensive. Even when the cost of dialysis is covered by the National Health Insurance, ancillary costs, like costs of transportation, medications, drugs like erythropoietin, needed to maintain the haemoglobin of these patients, and blood transfusions, are all costs that cannot be borne by the National Health Insurance. And these families struggle. For many families today, a diagnosis of chronic kidney failure or end-stage renal disease is equal to a death sentence. We can prevent this if we tackle the early causes of this condition.

I would thereby end by pleading that we hasten the process of passing legislation on organ transplantation. The advantages of such a law will be that this transplant will be done ethically, there will be organ banks that people can donate to, and people can give advance directives that if they are involved in an accident or anything that causes them to

lose their life, they are willing to donate their kidneys. This will permit the cadaveric harvesting of kidneys for use in transplant. In the present day, for one to get a kidney donated, one needs to get a living donor, and that is very challenging with a lot of ethical considerations.

So I plead with this House and the Hon Minister to consider bringing to this House the Bill on organ transplantation to help us manage the burden of end-stage kidney disease. Dialysis is not a permanent solution. The best solution is renal replacement.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leadership?

Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah (NDC — Essikadu-Ketan): Mr Speaker, thank you.

I would like to take this opportunity to thank the Hon Minister for Health, Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh, for such an important Statement.

Mr Speaker, according to the Statement, four million young people are suffering from end-stage kidney disease. Elsewhere, when it comes to kidney disease, it is usually people in their 60s to around 65. But here in Ghana, it is really young people. And for the reasons that the Minister had stated, a young person, average 46 years old, who has kidney disease, it is very devastating to the patient as well as to the family. Because that person has to be on dialysis

three times a week, and each session is about four hours. So Mondays, Wednesdays, and Fridays, that individual has to be in a dialysis unit for four hours. By the time they finish the session, they are completely wiped out. We have to take the blood, pass it through a dialysis machine, and return the blood to the patient. So after the session, there is not much they can do. They cannot go to work or do anything. So they just literally go home and sleep, or keep vomiting.

Mr Speaker, having end-stage kidney disease is one of the most devastating diseases that a young person can have. And for the same reasons that the Hon Member for Lambussie said, it is very important that we pass the organ transplant Bill.

Mr Speaker, currently, there are two options for transplantation. One, as the Hon Member spoke about, is a cadaveric. When we say cadaveric, we mean from a deceased person. The other option is a living-related kidney transplantation. Meaning that it is somebody the patient knows, a family member, who donates the kidney. Every individual has two kidneys, and a person can live with just one kidney. So, living-related kidney transplantation is when somebody would donate one of their kidneys to another individual, who is usually a family member.

Mr Speaker, currently, we are not doing a lot of kidney transplantations in this country. And that is where MahamaCares comes in. MahamaCares is doing a lot of specialist training to

bring specialists to this country so that people in Ghana will not have to travel outside the country to go to the Arab countries, the United States of America (USA) or the United Kingdom (UK) to get transplantation. We can do transplantation in Ghana with the right care and facilities.

Mr Speaker, incidentally, last month, we did four kidney transplantations at one of the hospitals in Ghana. All four of them were living-related. And thankfully, all four patients are doing extremely well right here in Ghana. So with MahamaCares, we can continue to have proper health care in Ghana, and we will not have to travel for that.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, on your behalf, I thank the Hon Minister for making the Statement on this very important issue.

Yes, Majority Leader?

4:53 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I believe that as agreed, we can go back to the Motion numbered 11, I believe, to continue with the debates. Mr Speaker, at Conclave, because my backlog is quite a lot, we had agreed that on our Side, each contributor would take five minutes, so we can take more of my numbers. The other Side had agreed that they would stick to their 10 minutes for Committee Chairs, so on my Side, Deputy Ministers and Committee Chairs, every contributor will do five minutes, so we can take more.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That had been agreed upon, so on the list, I have 16 and 8 people respectively.

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, I have an issue with that. I do not think we agreed firmly on that. Mr Speaker, we are very much aware that in debates, it is one against one. We do not want to set some bad precedents over here; that is my candid view about this. So, let us look at what has been the standard operation for debates in the House. I do not think we are going to finish in a very short period of time before closure if we adopt that approach to this debate. We, the Minority, are not in favour of that arrangement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I walked into Conclave to meet this arrangement being put in place and I was instructed as such. In fact, I went further to confirm with Hon Habib and Hon Jerry Ahmed about this arrangement when I received the respective lists from the Majority and the Minority Sides, and a confirmation was again given. So, I have some difficulties.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, my difficulty is that she actually raised this very point before the Speaker. It was the Speaker who presided —*[Interruption]*— Please, if the Minority Leader can —*[Interruption]*— All right. So, Mr Speaker, she raised the point because yesterday, we could not go on with the debates. So, we brought the backlogs from yesterday to today. Now, my proposal was that if we stick to the 10

minutes for the Committee Chairs, we may need more time. So, I proposed a more reasonable means to get a lot of our Members to contribute. So, I shortened the time for them and the Speaker said her claim that it would amount to setting a bad precedent was untenable since I was using a more reasonable means to solve the number problem. So, it is permissible for us to split our 10 minutes, so that instead of giving 10 minutes to one contributor, I was giving my 10 minutes to two contributors and that is permissible.

So, Mr Speaker overruled her and approved of the formula before we left Conclave.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any time at all the Speaker is using his wisdom to address a number problem, we oppose it and we run into a problem. So, if one Side is going to have one hour to speak and somebody decides that, as for the one hour that they are going to speak, they will let their Members use five minutes each and another decides that they want one person to use the entire one hour, it comes to the same thing. So, how do we address the number challenge when we are opposing this mechanism that has been approved by the Speaker and when leaving, he has given me a clear instruction that this is what has been agreed upon at Conclave?

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, I think this practice is very alien in this Chamber. The one we want to introduce. It is not the same as one person speaking for 10 minutes. We are here, look at the

time. I think it is about 5:00 p.m., and we are going to engage in this debate using five minutes for 16 people on that Side and then— Mr Speaker, we do not want to set something that is so bad.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: In terms of time, what difference does it make?

Ms Appiagyei: It makes a difference, because before someone gets up to speak, it takes some time before the person begins to even articulate his or her points. It is going to delay us further and it is untenable. One-to-one is what we know. This is so alien and you would remember that Mr Speaker himself gave a ruling.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I came to Conclave late and I am unable to overturn the decision of the Speaker and his instructions to me.

Mr Dafeamekpor: So, what was a problem for the Minority Side at Conclave was that those from my Side who originally have five minutes will have to be known. So, with the list I submitted, I indicated those who originally would have had 10 minutes. All of them had 10 minutes, but now, they will speak for five minutes and that became acceptable to them.

So, Mr Speaker, then let us do the 16 people on each Side. I have 16 Members, so let us proceed with the 16 people. They said they could not get 16 Members to debate today and that they would stick to their 10 minutes and let eight people who are available speak. How is this difficult?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, there is a number of issues. So, once it has been addressed this way, let us go by it.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I want to address two points on this matter.

One, I remember some months ago, the Majority Leader and Leader of Government Business raised this matter on the Floor and the Speaker made a definite ruling on the matter that although at Committee we go by ratio, when it comes to debates, it is one here, one there and nothing will change. As far as the records of this House would bear me out, there has not been an appeal to that decision.

Second, the Chief Whip of the Majority Caucus is now putting across a point that he wants to split his time. So, if it is one hour each allocated, he wants to split it to make it five for each Member. So, if it is an hour, instead of six people, he wants to do 12 and split it.

Mr Speaker, much as he may have his own good intention to solve his problem, that is not the practice of Parliament. Now, to suggest that we had said we do not have 16 people, so we only yielded to eight because we do not have the numbers and he has 16 and therefore, we should bring our 16, so he brings his 16, Mr Speaker, that is a different argument. If we need more time to debate the Message on the State of the Nation because they have Members who would want to speak, let us discuss that and then agree. But as it is, we have

agreed that tomorrow, Leaders are supposed to close the debate and if we want to extend it to Friday, we can do so. But I do not want us to weave a certain precedent that would come and haunt us in this Chamber.

5:02 p.m.

Mr Speaker, it is not a matter of “Mr Speaker has ruled”. Hon Dafeamekpor, listen to me.

What he is trying to suggest is to use a backdoor. I do not want to use a “Kweku Ananse” approach: have one, let me take two, but it is the same sharing formula. No, it will not be the same. It is “Kweku Ananse” strategy. It says, have one, let us share. For his, he will split it. When you split, they are not the same. When they split, it becomes two. If we are doing one-one and they have their eight, they should do their eight for ten minutes and we would do our eight for ten minutes. If they want to do five minutes each, we can proceed with the five minutes each. But I am pleading with them that because they are in Majority today, they want to have a full House and take the full loaf. They can never predict what will happen tomorrow.

Mr Speaker, that is exactly what it is.
[Interruption]

Mr Speaker, he makes it clear to me now. He has 16 and I should look for my 16. That is fair enough. If that is his argument, then that is fair enough, but I will not accept any ratio of two to one, because there is a ruling on it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the said ruling was delivered by the Rt Hon Speaker. The Rt Hon Speaker was at Conclave when these arrangements were made. I am unable to vary same. He can come later and vary same, but I am unable to vary what has been decided at Conclave and handed down to me. That is the difficulty that I have. If it is the case that we take eight people for today, having regard with the time, everybody speaks five minutes, then I am still within the range.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, fair enough. If the 16 is not working — The Majority Chief Whip is proposing 16 Members from each Side speaking for five minutes each. We do not have a problem with this. Save that because of time, let us do eight each and we continue tomorrow. I do not mind.

The remaining 8 can have a bite. This is not the first time that one side is having a majority. We have had 169 Members before. Hon Majority Leader, we have had 169 before. That is not how we treated your Minority. We have had 169 in this Chamber before.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think you have concluded on this matter. The Speaker himself, who ruled early on against my proposal that we have some kind of proportional opportunity when it comes to commenting on the Message on the State of the Nation and even the Budget, he decided to make some approvals that will be more accommodating, so that they maintain the length of time they get to debate. We enjoy the same length of time that we get

to debate, except that we use numerous debaters. I do not see why they should have a problem.

The argument I have heard several times from them is that the numbers are not important. The substance is what is important. So do not worry. If 20 people on this Side speak for 30 minutes and say nothing valuable, why is he worried? If only seven people on their Side speak for 30 minutes and say something very valuable, his own argument that substance is what is important will prevail. So let us accommodate one another. The Speaker has already made the arrangement and communicated it to the First Deputy Speaker. As he indicates, he has to go according to that arrangement. Let us try it today and see how it goes.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, I do not want my Colleague to quote me out of context; I do not want him to quote me out of context. Mr Speaker, I maintain that the Majority is taking an undue advantage of their numbers. This is not an end to the democracy we have. There is an election ahead. We have had 169 in this Chamber. We did not bring such arguments. Mr Speaker, this thing of it is two, divided into two and our Side will subdivide it into two is not the same. It is a backdoor approach. I also do not want the Rt Hon Speaker himself to be quoted in public because the Rt Hon Speaker has ruled. Any time I have administratively approached the Speaker on matters that I felt administratively could be resolved, he always insisted that I use a Motion and if the House decides, it is only

through a proper application on the Floor that same can be varied. Mr Speaker, I do not want to believe.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, can I conclude? Majority Leader spoke; he finished—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I do not want you to be doing that invitation. I just want to admonish. Certain things cannot always be by bringing a Motion.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader spoke, he did not interrupt. At least, he should let me finish so he can come in. He has unended opportunity to admonish and come in. The Majority Leader spoke, there was no interjection.

Mr Speaker, what I am saying is that the Speaker should not be invited into this matter. Matters that perhaps is discussed at Conclave, we should not create the impression that the Speaker can rule on a matter and then vary the same ruling. I do not want that impression to be created. I am ready for a workable approach. The Majority Chief Whip has suggested that we do 8 each and continue tomorrow. He says he wants us to do 16 each. That is fine. If he wants us to do 16 each, if that is his suggestion, we are ready. We will marshal our 16. He should get his 16 Members ready. Let us start.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Everybody speaks for five minutes.

Starting from the Minority Side, I will give the floor to Hon Patrick Boamah. You are speaking for five minutes.

MOTION

Message on the State of the Nation, 2026

[Continuation of debate from 5th March, 2026]

5:13 p.m.

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah (NPP — Okaikwei Central): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make some few comments on the President's message to the House. Mr Speaker, the President came here to perform his constitutional duty in accordance with Article 67 of the 1992 Constitution. Mr Speaker, these five minutes are not going to make this debate interesting, but I will make some points and sit down.

Mr Speaker, the world is going through some turmoil. We are experiencing some hikes in petroleum products globally. Crude oil is now selling over US\$100 on the world market. We have been promised a resilient economy and we trust that no excuses will be brought to the Floor when this affects our national Budget.

Mr Speaker, we just read a report by a think tank in education in this country, Africa Education Watch, that over 30,000 basic schools or classrooms have remained without teachers since 2025. This is a worrying statistic that every

serious government must take a closer look at. For want of time, I will not go into detail because it affects the very progress of our children in the educational sector.

Mr Speaker, public sector workers have all been agitating for better wages. In the President's address to this House, we did not hear much about his plans and his strategy to assuage the difficulties being meted out to public sector workers. Today, Civil and Local Government Staff Association of Ghana (CLOGSAG) is on strike. Today, for the Single-Spine Salary Structure, some workers have as high as 53 per cent allowance on their basic pay, while their counterparts, including those in the same organisation, do not have a single allowance. This is close to over 53 per cent allowance, and PSU has zero percent. There is serious labour disconnect or discrimination that has to be looked at. There is so much labour agitation and we do not want a disruption in the labour front. The Government, being so caring as they say, should take the right steps to address this agitation on the labour front. H. E., the President also mentioned that Ghana was ready for business, but in a country where utility prices keep changing by the day, week and hour, it is not interesting for any business to thrive.

I took a glance at the Fraser Report on the mining sector and the Global Investment Attractive Index for 2024. Ghana ranked 46 out of 82. In 2025, Ghana ranked 53 out of 68. In 2024, the Global Policy Perception Index, Ghana ranked 46 out of 82 and 50 out of 68. In the Global Best Practises Mineral

Potential Index, Ghana ranked 34 out of 58 and 35 out of 41.

Mr Speaker, I took a very close look at the NDC manifesto and I noticed that the President failed to report on the establishment of the National Women's Bank, to support female entrepreneurs on page 12 of the NDC manifesto. There was no report on the establishment of the cocoa colleges in the cocoa growing areas to train cocoa farmers and extension officers as stated on page 41. The tariff increases are a major feature in the last statement by the President—

Mr Sanja Nanja (NDC — Atebubu/Amantin): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Motion that was ably moved by the Hon Member for Bolgatanga Central, that this House thanks H. E., the President of the Republic for the Message on the State of the Nation which he delivered to Parliament on Friday, 27th February, 2026.

Mr Speaker, over the years, illegal and irresponsible mining, also known as (a.k.a.) *galamsey*, has been a major problem facing our nation, Ghana. But unfortunately, government after government has failed to combat this canker.

Two related factors have been identified as the inhibiting factors not allowing the fight against *galamsey* to succeed, and these are weak enforcement and lack of political will. The President, in his Message on the State of the Nation, reaffirmed his position to fight the *galamsey*. He stated that the focus is now

on the big fish and not the lower offenders. In 2023 and 2024, out of the 845 persons who were arrested in relation to the *galamsey*, it is sad to note that the previous government only prosecuted 35. That is 4 per cent. And the breakdown is as follows: In 2023, 218 were arrested, and only 24 were prosecuted. In 2024, we have 627 arrested, and only 11 were prosecuted.

Mr Speaker, the President in the Message on the State of the Nation, has declared that no excavator will be missing this time around. We remember 500 excavators in the previous government were seized, and these excavators miraculously grew wings and flew out of the country. Up to date, we cannot find them. This time around, the excavators are tamed. The excavators can no longer fly because we have taken measures. Tracking devices have been put on the excavators, and they are being monitored wherever they go.

Just last week, over 1,000 Changfang machines, which were bound for *galamsey* areas, were intercepted at the Tema Harbour by the Environmental Protection Authority (EPA). This is a boost toward the fight against *galamsey*. Mr Speaker, if we go to areas with *galamsey*, there are hundreds of cases pending at the courts. H. E. the President and his team have deployed specialised prosecutorial teams to go and fast-track these cases. Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Frank Yeboah, you have five minutes.

Mr Frank Yeboah (NPP — Atwima Nwabiagya North): Thank you, Mr Speaker for the opportunity to comment on the President's Message on the State of the Nation that was delivered to us on 27th February, 2026.

5:22 p.m. —

[HON SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR ANDREW ASIAMAH AMOAKO,
IN THE CHAIR]

Mr Yeboah: Mr Speaker, listening to the President's speech, one would safely assume that Ghana has suddenly become a paradise for healthcare delivery. But that is not the case.

On the issue of nursing, the President boldly declared, and I quote "Nursing training allowances have been regularised, application fees reduced, and the no-fee stress initiative introduced to ease access to training". There is emphasis on ease access to training. These are very comforting words.

While the President was in this Chamber, delivering these sweet words and comforting words, the Minister for Health, Hon Kwabena Mintah Akandoh, was in Nalerigu, aggressively causing the immediate suspension of the Nalerigu Nursing Training College principal. What crime did this man commit? The Minister is saying that the man admitted 2,750 students against the Government's approved cap of 750. The justification the Minister gave was that it would burden the Government's no-fee stress policy and also affect the payment of allowances.

Mr Speaker, I ask the House, sincerely, is it an achievement to deny 2,000 students who are qualified admission to the Nursing Training College because the Government or the President wants to save face on the populist campaign promise made to Ghanaians in 2024?

5:23 p.m.

Mr Speaker, if we want to look at the true state of the health sector in Ghana, then we have to look at the cocoa farmer in my Constituency in Worapong in Atwima Nwabiagya North, or Sefwi Bodi in the Western North Region, Mr Speaker, that cocoa farmer had assurance of a life-saving anti-snake serum delivered swiftly by a zipline drone system under the previous government. But today, that assurance is gone because the Government has suspended the contract between the Government and the zipline.

Mr Speaker, today, if that cocoa farmer goes to his farm and gets bitten by a snake, the farmer will have to find his own way of getting transport to the nearest hospital before the anti-snake serum can be administered. Where is the money for transport going to come from? The money is going to come from the same proceeds from the sale of cocoa beans that the Government has slashed by over GHC1,000 per bag. Mr Speaker, and if that farmer is able to get to the hospital and get the serum and returns, the farmer is going to meet *dumsor* because *dumsor* has returned, or the GHC100 prepaid credit he bought two days ago, which used to last for two

weeks, unfortunately, has lasted for two days. Therefore, there is *dumsor*, and the farmer will find it difficult to administer the medication that was given to him by paramedics.

Mr Speaker, this is the true state of our health sector now. *Ghanafoɔ y'ayɛ mɔbo* under NDC. Mr Speaker, *yerebreɛ*. To wit: Ghanaians are suffering under the NDC. God should come to our aid.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me now turn to Hon Frank Afriyie, Member of Parliament for Afadjato South. Hon Member, you have five minutes. Your time starts now.

Mr Frank Afriyie (NDC — Afadjato South): Thank you very much, my revered Speaker. Mr Speaker, while sharing my perspectives on the President's Message on the State of the Nation, permit me to convey a multitude of gratitude and appreciation to H. E. the President, for delivering what has globally been accepted as a magnificently outstanding, evidence-based, sector-by-sector, blow-by-blow, detailed-but-significant account of his stewardship to the people of this country.

Mr Speaker, when we talk about reset, this is the evidence of the reset that we have talked about. [*Hear! Hear!*] Our governance is meaningless unless it delivers concrete, impactful, purposeful outcomes to its citizenry. Mr Speaker, we have crafted the Local Governance Act, just so the 40 per cent of our compatriots who live in rural settings will be taken care of.

Mr Speaker, through your facilitation, I just returned from the Western and Central Regions as a Member of your noble Committee on Local Government and Rural Development. I was extremely excited at the rate of development we are witnessing under H. E. John Dramani Mahama. [*Hear! Hear!*] Mr Speaker, when our Colleagues across the aisle had the opportunity for eight good years, local governance was reduced to mere devolution of power and deconcentration of offices. Today, His Excellency is giving true meaning to local governance. The Municipal, Metropolitan, and District Assemblies are well-resourced. I will give you a tangible example. If we go to the Western Region, there is a municipality called Effia. Mr Speaker, in the year 2024, under the reign of H. E. Akufo-Addo, the whole year, that municipality had only GH¢2.7 million. Today, under H. E. John Dramani Mahama, the same municipality for one year had GH¢26 million. Mr Speaker, look at the yawning gap between GH¢2.7 million and GH¢26 million. No wonder they are delivering; they are performing efficiently and effectively.

Mr Speaker, this is what we are talking about when we say we need to incentivise our local base, create jobs, and unleash opportunities. This is what H. E. John Dramani Mahama is doing. But, Mr Speaker, most importantly, I want to also put on record that this Government is not on autopilot as we have had in the last eight years. The Government is being regulated. There are guidelines for spending these moneys. There is a formula, so the

amount of money that has been sufficiently delivered, a section is supposed to create school desks for our pupils. Research and data by Africa Education Watch clearly shows that 2.3 million of our pupils in public schools in Ghana lack desks. That is why His Excellency has directed that a segment of this money be used to create desks at the district level.

Mr Speaker, the Safe Water Network, a non-government organisation (NGO), has revealed that 44 per cent of Ghanaians lack access to safe and clean water. H. E. John Dramani Mahama has directed that a percentage of the money to the various assemblies be used in drilling boreholes and creating water. I am excited to know that while we were in the Western Region, significant amounts of these boreholes have already been drilled and mechanised for our people. So, by a rough estimate, by 2028, we will be drilling about 5,000 boreholes. This should be enough to give about half a million Ghanaians access to safe, clean, potable water. Anyone who gives water gives life. Mahama is giving water. Mahama is giving Community-based Health Planning and Services (CHPS) compound. By 2028, we would have built about 500 plus CHPS compounds so that every Ghanaian can have access and take advantage of the free medical care policy of H. E. John Dramani Mahama.

Mr Speaker, this is the governance we are talking about, and if you indulge me, I will use the *Hansard* of this House, particularly in reference to today, I call him Bishop Armah-Kofi Buah. Mr

Speaker, the last Message on the State of the Nation that President Akufo-Addo delivered to this House, this was his response to President—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let us welcome Hon Michael Baafi Okyere. Hon Member, you have five minutes.

Mr Michael Baafi Okyere (NPP — New Juaben South): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I rise to comment on the Message on the State of the Nation ably delivered by the President in this respected House. Mr Speaker, I would like to draw the attention of this august House to the fact that Ghana is still the host of the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) that has come to stay. The AfCFTA, which is a very important concept of the Customs Union that Africa has adopted, is being hosted by this country. For that matter, we have to respect the dictates and protocols of AfCFTA.

Mr Speaker, the President in the Message on the State of the Nation Address clearly made a statement that he wants to encourage a new policy called the export policy to help the country to be able to focus attention on intra-African trade. We believe that AfCFTA has come to bless Africa so that we will be able to trade among ourselves; duty free, quota free. However, Ghana, as the host of this concept, must be seen as a champion, not just a participant; we have to show leadership. And showing leadership means that we have to do things to enhance our status as a country that is hosting the Secretariat.

It will interest you to note that the President, in his Message on the State of the Nation, said that Ghana Export-Import (GEXIM) Bank funding will be enhanced. The AfCFTA's Small and Medium-sized Enterprises (SMEs) readiness programme will also come into force. These are things that we were expecting to see in the country. But in reality, these are nothing. We cannot find it anywhere in this country. This means that the country is not positioning itself well to take full advantage of the AfCFTA.

5:53 p.m.

As of now, out of the 55 African countries, 54 African countries have signed the agreement. Forty-eight African countries have ratified the agreement, which means that the agreement has come to stay, which is the biggest customs union in the whole world. And I believe that, as a country, we have to be seen to be so serious about the African Continental Free Trade Area.

Mr Speaker, it is also interesting to note that the President made a huge announcement that has come to be a mere announcement: announcing that there are going to be three Government factories to be established within this country. Mr Speaker, this was just an announcement. As of now, nothing seriously has been done as far as the establishment of these factories is concerned. I can confidently tell you that preparatory works are only underway. There has not been any serious engagement with the Ghanaian that has been selected to take the lead or promote

the business on behalf of Ghana. So, I believe that this was just an announcement. It did not show anything serious, and it did not speak well of us as a country that is ready to create a lot of businesses.

Mr Speaker, it is interesting to note that the President said that that factory is going to create about 1.7 million jobs, total factory work, which I believe would have encouraged a lot of people to be part of the whole arrangement. But Government alone may not be able to do it. Note that the 24-Hour Economy that they were trying to bring could have helped in this matter if they had allowed the private sector to come in. The private sector could have come in by leading to set up Government factories. As I speak, there are three major Government factories in this country that employ about 500,000 people, both direct and indirect jobs. I believe that the Government should have done more by engaging the private sector, giving them good incentive package that can encourage a lot of people to take part of this programme.

The last point that I want to talk about is the fact that the President declared the country as being ready for business. Being ready for business means that we are ready to open up. We are ready to also share data. One of the key things that the President did not do was to give us data on specific investments, especially foreign direct investment that we have attracted into this country. As of now, neither the President nor any person here can specifically tell us how much money we received as a country in attracting

foreign direct investment into this country, which is not too good for us as a country. So, any foreigner who wants to invest in this country—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Baafi.

Let us turn to Hon Bede Ziedeng. Hon Member, you have five minutes.

Mr Bede Anwataazumo Zeideng (NDC — Lawra) Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the debate on the Message of the State of the Nation delivered by H. E. John Dramani Mahama, President of the Republic of Ghana, Commander-in-Chief of the Ghana Armed Forces, pursuant to Article 67 of the 1992 Constitution, which he delivered with dignity, clarity, and confidence.

Mr Speaker, let me begin with the issue of roads. Roads are not merely infrastructure. They are arteries through which opportunity flows to our people. When roads improve, markets expand, farmers prosper, and communities move from isolation to participation. If we are serious about agricultural transformation, then we must equally be serious about the roads that carry food from our farms to our markets. The President announced the construction of the Accra-Kumasi Expressway during his address. And, Mr Speaker, let me say that this is not just another road project. This is a transformational infrastructural vision. Indeed, the Expressway will become one of the most strategic road corridors in the history of this country, comparable only to the famous Accra-Tema Motorway

constructed by the first President of the Republic of Ghana, Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah. The Expressway will cover approximately 198.7 kilometres, connecting Accra to Kumasi. And let me say this respectfully to our Colleagues on the other Side: Infrastructure of this magnitude requires vision, courage, and leadership, and not cynicism.

Mr Speaker, I say this with personal experience. A few weeks ago, I had the privilege of attending a parliamentary training workshop in the Philippines. While there, I experienced firsthand what modern expressway infrastructure can do for a nation. Mr Speaker, the Philippines has seven major expressways, not one, with two prominent ones being the North Luzon Expressway, otherwise known as NLEX, and the South Luzon Expressway, otherwise known as SLEX. Some sections carry between four to eight lanes, and other sections carry as many as 11 to 13 lanes. The Philippines has a population of about 120 million, and Manila, the capital, has a population of 30 million and yet, because of this wonderful road network, it is movement relatively manageable in that country.

Mr Speaker, let me move to the Big Push. This initiative will ensure that strategic roads across all 16 regions of Ghana will benefit from accelerated infrastructure development. I would like to, on this occasion, on behalf of the people of the Upper West Region, express profound gratitude to the President for including critical roads in our region under this programme. Mr Speaker, historically, the Upper West

Region has not received much infrastructural development. In fact, at some point in time, we had the least kilometrage of paved roads in the country. So, we commend and thank the President for including us in the Big Push Programme. Mr Speaker, the roads which have been included include the following. Sawla-Wa Road, Navrongo-Sesili-Tumu Road, Tumu-Han-Wa Road, Tumu-Han-Lawra Road, and then Wa-Hamile Road. These roads will certainly open up the Upper West Region.

Let me, Mr Speaker, move to aviation, that is, transport. The President announced the construction of three new airports, including the Wa Airport. I was privileged to be part of the team that acquired the site for the new airport, that is at Kperisi, and this was in 1985. The people have been waiting for the construction of—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Bede, thank you very much.

Let us now turn our attention to Hon Kingsley Agyemang. Hon Member, you have five minutes.

Dr Kingsley Agyemang (NPP — Abuakwa South): Mr Speaker, thank you very much, for the opportunity to make some comments on the Message on the State of the Nation by His Excellency the President. Listening to the debate and the commentary from the other Side, one begins to wonder if it is really the Message on the State of the Nation that the President presented to us.

Mr Speaker, if you indulge me, I want us to go to page 11 of the address by the President, specifically paragraph 2, and I want to quote him. He said:

“Our nation is on the runway. It is in take-off mode, and you are all advised to fasten your seatbelts”.

Mr Speaker, this means that it has taken the President 15 months, if he were the captain of an aeroplane, to just push back and taxi to a runway.

5:43 p.m.

I mean, it is not surprising that front-line policies that they mentioned in their Manifesto, such as the Big Push, which they are debating around as perspectives or perceptions and not realities, has not seen the light of day. Their famous 24-Hour Economy, the expected number of employments that they ought to have done, have all not materialised, because for 15 months, the President was pushing back to taxi to a runway. So, if one has a flight duration of say four hours, one has used basically one hour or one hour, 30 minutes, just to push back and taxi to a runway. I believe this is not the way to go, and we have to be more serious with the way we govern our country.

Mr Speaker, the President's Statement or Address was interspersed with a lot of levity. Why do I say this? If we go to page 27, where he sought to address a problem, with your permission I quote:

“Today, non-communicable diseases (NCD) accounts for over 40 per

cent of all deaths in Ghana and remain a major case of household poverty.”

In a nutshell, what the President is telling us is that, one out of every two deaths that happens in this country is as a result of an NCD. A very big problem. If the President of a country is confronted with a situation where one out of two deaths happens and it comes from a categorisation of a public health called an NCD or non-communicable disease—And you will laugh at this. His solution to this huge or elephant-type problem was the creation of a Ghana Medical Trust Fund, what all of them are alluding to as MahamaCares. Mr Speaker, he has this huge problem that he is confronted with as a President and his solution was to take 80 per cent of this Fund, coming from an existing Fund that we are already struggling with, that is, the 20 per cent from the National Health Insurance Authority. Big problems require big solutions and this solution that has been suggested or addressed by the President in his Message on the State of the Nation is very unfortunate.

Mr Speaker, we cannot continue this way. How can he take 80 per cent from the Fund for an existing problem or a problem that is causing one out of two deaths that happens in this country, that is, non-communicable disease? *[Interruption]* Why this? I think there should be more rigorous financing when it comes to health care. The mere fact that he wants to etch his name in what President Kufuor did by bringing about economic accessibility to health care, where no one is denied health care

because of their low socioeconomic setting does not mean that they should be in a hurry to bring about something.

Policies must be very thoughtful and we must take the people of this country very seriously. One out of two deaths cannot be solved by bringing about what they call MahamaCares. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Dr Kingsley Agyemang. So, we turn to Hon Nii Kotey Ashie. Hon Member, nobody will interject you. You have five minutes.

Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (NDC — Odododiodioo): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I believe in your statement that you will not allow anyone to heckle me. Mr Speaker, I also want to take the opportunity to thank H. E. President John Dramani Mahama, for the prudent management of this economy and also to the venerable Ato Forson for the great work he is doing in Ghana's economy.

Mr Speaker, I wonder why lately, whenever we decide to discuss matters of the economy, our Colleagues are quick enough to jump on matters of cocoa and cocoa farmers. Mr Speaker, I have in my hands a Statement made today in this House as part of the Auditor-General's Reports. In this document, without prejudice, it is being alleged that about GH¢18 billion is at large and what I want to say is that if they had managed the economy this well, this whopping amount of GH¢18 billion would have

been used to cushion the cocoa farmer. What we are doing today is to manage the mess they created.

Mr Speaker, H.E. John Dramani Mahama has managed the economy so well that today inflation is as low as about 3.3 per cent and this is gradually reflecting in the practical lives of our people. Today, the amount of money you will spend to buy a bag of rice is far less than what you would have used to do same under the NPP. He knows that Ghana as a country needs to shock-absorb its economy so that the gains we have made so far will not derail and that is why His Excellency the President has instituted what the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP), which was brought to this House to be approved. What is the purpose? It is to ensure that we will be able to accumulate about 15 months of import cover by 2028 to shock-absorb Ghana from any external insecurities or stabilities that may occur.

Mr Speaker, the Akufo-Addo-Bawumia-led Government did not have this foresight. When COVID-19 struck, they found themselves wanting to the extent that they had to run from one country to another borrowing everywhere. They borrowed from our local market, international market, International Monetary Fund (IMF) and all the other Bretton Woods just begging. But we are being proactive to ensure that we build Ghana's base to the extent that whenever there are any external shocks, we will be able to manage that and it will not affect the Ghanaian that bad.

Mr Speaker, under the NPP, they made the Ghanaian lose confidence in that famous phrase, what I call the phrase of destiny, in Dr Kwame Nkrumah's independence delivery, that the black man is capable of managing his own affairs. They made the Ghanaian lose so much hope that the Ghanaian thought, no, we blacks cannot manage our own affairs. But today, thanks to H.E. President John Dramani Mahama, hope has brought to the lives of the Ghanaian and Metropolitan, Municipal and District Assemblies (MMDAs) are receiving whooping amounts of moneys they have not seen in decades. Today, the Ghana Medical Trust Fund that he is referring to has come to stay. But if they knew that this is how bad NCDs is affecting our people, what did they do during that time? Today, as we speak, six new regional hospitals are being built in the regions they created and left the people to suffer.

Mr Speaker, today, the La General Hospital is being built. Today, MahamaCares is here to save lives. *Nkokɔ Nketenketɛ* is also here to stay. We will develop this economy. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, let us now turn to Hon Shirley Kyei. You have five minutes.

Ms Shirley Kyei (NPP — Atwima Nwabiagya South): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Message on the State of the Nation delivered to this honourable House by H.E. President John Dramani Mahama in fulfilment of his constitutional obligation.

Mr Speaker, the President stood in this House and declared that Ghana is back, that Ghana is working again and is open for business.

5:53 p.m.

With respect, Mr Speaker, Ghana is not working for everyone as the President would like us to believe. In fact, many of us identify with our cocoa farmers and their dependents, the rice, the cashew, the maize farmers and all other farmers who are struggling to sell their produce even at “*donkomi*” prices. Mr Speaker, the many people who were laid off when this Government took office, the youth who are unemployed out there, all feel that Ghana is regressing.

Mr Speaker, today, *dumsor* is gradually creeping back. The comrades in this House promised a stable energy supply as the foundation for the 24-Hour Economy and for the development of this country. Yet today, even a regular eight-hour energy supply cannot be guaranteed. These outages are now labelled as “planned and unplanned maintenance”, “emergency”, “unscheduled and scheduled repairs”. They can call it all the names in this world and avoid *dumsor* or load shedding, but the truth is that if they toss it upside down, if they flip it sideways, Mr Speaker, they can turn it inside out and call it whatever. The effect and the value are the same, a stark darkness.

Mr Speaker, the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG) continues to publish widespread outage schedules. How can a

three-shift, 24-Hour Economy survive when a one-shift cannot rely on uninterrupted power? As if these outages are not bad enough. Today, we have electricity tariffs that have cumulatively increased to about 28 per cent. Prepaid metres deplete faster than Usain Bolt. Mr Speaker, how can they tell me Ghana is working again when we cannot have power?

Mr Speaker, across our markets, in Agboghloshie, Fomena, Akatsi, Kejetia, Adum, Nkawie, Abuakwa, Sepase markets and beyond, small businesses are struggling. Today, the cold store operator is losing stock. Our barbers, hairdressers, seamstresses, and small business operators, like our block-making factory operators, are all feeling the pinch. The sad truth is that we have seen this movie before. We have seen this movie before, and it did not end well. If it were a Kumawood movie, we would dub it, *Temanmufɔ amanehunu*, Part one and two.

Mr Speaker, let me take you to a community engagement I had over the weekend. Maame Akua Afriyie in Nkawie-Kuma would like me to ask the President if *dumsor* is back because she would like to know so she can plan. If indeed we are experiencing power outages, we would like the President to come out with a clear timetable so that businesses and individuals can plan. How can we say Ghana is working again and is open for business when power, the backbone of productivity, is unaffordable, unreliable and unpredictable?

Mr Speaker, permit me to take you to the housing sector. In the President's maiden address to this House, he said,

and I quote, “the quality of life in any nation relies significantly on wealth—”

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Theresa Awuni is not here. So, let us turn to Prof Ayensu-Danquah. Hon Member, you have five minutes.

Deputy Minister for Health (Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me this opportunity to comment on the Message on the State of the Nation.

Mr Speaker, I would like to commend the President for his thoroughness, insightfulness and clear vision for the country. The President stood on his feet for over three hours to lay down a visionary, consistent and clear-cut agenda with nothing but evidence-based analysis. He detailed how he will move this country towards a broader resetting agenda of “Kwame Nkrumah proportions.”

Mr Speaker, I will refer to His Excellency, President John Dramani Mahama as Nkrumah 2.0. The true state of the health of Ghana, is that the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS), has been uncapped. Under uncapping, we had 3.4 billion extra funds in 2025, all of which have been pumped back into the health sector. We came out with arrears in 2019, and all the arrears have been paid. We have paid 4.1 billion in claims as of the end of 2025, to the extent that all claims are paid at the end of each month. No health care provider is owed by NHIS. We have a three-month window to pay all claims. The tariffs have undergone revision, and new tariffs are awaiting ministerial approval.

Mr Speaker, when it comes to MahamaCares, it was set up because 43 per cent of mortalities in the country were based on non-communicable diseases, cancers and other rare conditions. MahamaCares was started in September 2025, and it has been fully implemented. The MahamaCares has done the patient support programmes for all non-communicable diseases, including prostate cancer, breast cancer, colon cancer, cervical cancer and other cancers. Mr Speaker, as of date, MahamaCares has paid GHC3.2 million for treatment of Ghanaians, including treatment for brain surgeries, open heart surgeries, chemotherapy, radiation therapy and minimally invasive procedures.

Mr Speaker, currently, MahamaCares is established in three cardiac centres: Kumasi, Tamale and Korle Bu Teaching Hospital. These are not just cardiac catheterisation centres, but they are fully cardiac centres. Currently, most Ghanaians travel outside the country to access proper cardiac care. With these three cardiac centres, no Ghanaian will have to travel outside the country to access quality, high-level, specialised care. We can have that quality, high-level, specialised cardiac care right here in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, MahamaCares is also working on training our specialists in this country. Currently, MahamaCares is training 100 specialised nurses in areas that are very difficult to find nurses, like oncology, nurses who take care of cancer, like nephrology, nurses who take care of kidney diseases, endocrinology,

nurses who take care of endocrine problems, cardiology, neurology and critical care. Currently, we have a deficit of critical care nurses in this country, and MahamaCares has put a fund together to train 100 of these nurses.

MahamaCares is also working with the Ghana College of Pharmacy to train 100 pharmaceutical specialists. When we come to free primary health care, the policy will be launched next month. The idea is that, finally, Ghanaians at the Community-based Health Planning and Services (CHPS) level, at the health centre level and also at the polyclinic level will enter the health system and get free health care.

6:03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, *wompe wei na wope den* to wit, if we do not like this, what do we like?

Mr Speaker, President John Mahama—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: From Dr Ayensu, let me go to Prof Kingsley Nyarko.

Prof, you have five minutes.

Prof Kingsley Nyarko (NPP — Kwadaso): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to add my voice to Motion numbered 11 on the Message on the State of the Nation delivered by the President on 27th February this year, and moved on 3rd March this year by the Hon Member for Bolgatanga Central, Mr Isaac Adongo, and seconded by the Hon Member for Assin South, Mr Ntim Fordjour.

Mr Speaker, honestly, I was reluctant to take part in the debate on the Message on the State of the Nation delivered by the President, because I saw no difference between his delivery on 27th February, and the one he delivered last year, and also from the Budget Statement that was delivered by the Minister for Finance; I saw no difference. The only striking element I saw was just lamentations and blame games. That is all.

Mr Speaker, our Friends tell us that the economy is robust, and that it is doing well, and that Inflation has come down to 3.3 per cent. They are saying that the cedi is now stronger against the major trading currencies, and that Gross Domestic Product (GDP) is about 6.6 per cent or so.

Mr Speaker, in all this, the Government is not able to pay cocoa farmers, who, through no fault of theirs, have found themselves in this precarious situation. If the economy is doing well, then we are expecting the Government, headed by President John Dramani Mahama, to give them some bailouts. That would suggest that he is the President who thinks about the people and the economy is doing well. It is far from that.

Mr Speaker, they promised us that they were going to create jobs, and that jobs were going to be easy for the Ghanaian youth. Mr Speaker, where are the jobs? The President told us that he has created about one million jobs, but the records show that that is not the case. The Ghana Statistical Service gave a figure of 330,000.

Mr Speaker, what he failed to tell us was to indicate to us the various sectors, and how much employment has been created. That was not done. The productive sectors of this economy are struggling. In the agricultural sector, they cannot even create jobs. Nana Akufo-Addo and Dr Bawumia created jobs, and we saw their jobs. All the interventions that were done, created some jobs.

Mr Speaker, the Free Senior High School policy gave over 100,000 jobs to Ghanaians. The ambulances to the constituencies also created jobs. The National Identification Authority (NIA) which produced Ghana cards also created jobs. The drone delivery system created jobs.

Mr Speaker, all our interventions created jobs. The NDC administration, under President John Dramani Mahama, cannot even create jobs, and they told the Ghanaians that they were going to do 1-3-3. Where is the 1-3-3? It is over a year, 15 months in office, where is the 1-3-3? There is none; there is nothing. At times, I ask myself, when Ghanaians were clamoring for President John Dramani Mahama, were Ghanaians thinking that he was going to do something different? Were Ghanaians thinking that John Dramani Mahama that they saw between 2012 and 2016, was capable of creating jobs? I sit down and I laugh, because this man, with all due respect, does not have the capacity to create jobs.

Mr Speaker, as we speak, in Parliament, we are embarking on cost-

cutting measures. Under the NPP administration, there were no restrictions on travels in terms of capacity building. But under the NDC, as we speak right now, all these have been curtailed. They are sitting there, and they know what I am talking about.

Mr Speaker, the Message on the State of the Nation did not offer any hope to the Ghanaian. We are tired of the lamentations and the blame games—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, thank you very much. It is now the turn of Hon Yussif Sulemana, Member of Parliament for Bole Bamboi. You have five minutes.

Alhaji Yusif Sulemana (NDC — Bole Bamboi): Mr Speaker, it is rather unfortunate that this time is not an ideal time for me to debate. I say so because yesterday we appealed that we will be having a Muslim programme around this time. It is time for me to break my fast, and it is time for me to join my Colleagues to celebrate the Night of Power. So, regrettably, I am unable to debate. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, let us turn to Hon Charles Agbeve.

Mr Charles Akwasi Agbeve (NDC — Agotime-Ziope): Mr Speaker, I also rise to thank the President for fulfilling the Constitutional mandate of coming to give us the Message on the State of the Nation.

Mr Speaker, last year, we procured vaccines at a cost of US\$24.5 million. This year, 2026, we are procuring vaccines at US\$49.5 million.

Next year is projected to reach US\$54 million. These are the costs incurred by the Government in procuring 68mmunizati vaccines from Gavi. By 2029, we will exit the Gavi system, and by 2030, the Government is supposed to fully bear the cost of 68mmunization in this country.

Mr Speaker, it is for this reason that His Excellency the President, in his Message on the State of the Nation, stated that he would give the National Vaccine Institute, US\$50 million.

Mr Speaker, this is to help us not overly depend on external sources for vaccines. This is also to help us attain vaccine sovereignty and secure health security for our people.

Mr Speaker, the National Vaccine Institute is supposed to use the US\$50 million for one, support the two emerging manufacturing vaccine companies in the pharmaceutical hub. Two, help equip our researchers and also our scientists in vaccine production. We do not have that technology. And finally, improve our research and development and build the capacity of the two regulatory companies in the vaccine space; that is the Food and Drugs Authority (FDA) and the National Vaccine Institute.

Mr Speaker, the National Vaccine Institute will use that to build a multi-sectoral dimensional lab which will equip our scientists to design, improve and help develop vaccines today and for the future.

Also, interestingly, Mr Speaker, one of the very important things that has happened is the Government partnering with the private sector, Atlantic Lifesciences Limited, to partner with a foreign company, that is the PT Bio Farma of Indonesia, to help develop tech transfer for us to produce a vaccine in Ghana.

6:13 p.m.

Mr Speaker, for the first time, after 69 years of independence, Ghana will produce its first vaccine through the National Vaccine Institute. This particular vaccine is the Tetanus Diphtheria, and it is going to be produced here in Ghana through the tech transfer. This product will also achieve the advanced market commitment framework, which is being developed by the Ministry of Health and the National Vaccine Institute. Mr Speaker, this milestone represents a very historic breakthrough, and we must acknowledge the work of the emerging vaccine manufacturing companies, Atlantic Life Sciences, and the DEK Vaccine Limited.

Mr Speaker, there is an opportunity for Ghana to take advantage of this foundation the President is helping us build. By 2024, Africa wants to source all its vaccines locally, at least 60 per cent of it. If this foundation is built, Ghana can take advantage of it to become the regional hub for vaccine manufacturing, vaccine production, vaccine innovations, and it will produce the human resource and, export them to other African countries which need their support. Mr Speaker, with this

development, we will guarantee uninterrupted access to life-saving vaccines for infants, neonates, children, and the future generation of this country.

I thank the President very much for the support of the National Vaccine Institute. With these few words, we thank you very much for the Statement.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Let me now turn to Member of Parliament for Tema Central, Charles Forson. Hon Member, you have five minutes.

Mr Charles Forson (NPP — Tema Central): Mr Speaker, I rise to comment on the Message on the State of the Nation delivered by the President of the Republic in fulfilment of Article 67. Mr Speaker, it was a long three hours of lamentation, I must say. The President told the House that he has delivered one million jobs to the good people of Ghana, meaning that, per the numbers, every constituency may have gotten approximately about 3,600 or something, but I wish to contextualise things in the case of Tema Central. Tema Central, be it NDC or NPP, we are brothers and sisters. Some few weeks ago, the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS) office was locked by no less a person than the NDC Constituency Chairman, ably supported by the Constituency Secretary, together with all the functional executives in the world, all because of one job placement. They locked the place. Mr Speaker, the President may come here and throw out all the numbers, but chickens will surely come home to roost.

With regards to chickens, the President also mentioned that he has given some 720,000-day-old chicks to some 13,000 individuals, meaning that every person may have gotten about 55. But when we go to the market, some day-old chicks cost as less as GH¢2.00 and even GH¢1.00. Let me use the average of even GH¢10.00, meaning that he is trying to tell us that he is empowering people with just GH¢550.00 or GH¢110.00. Is that the transformational drive that he was talking about?

Mr Speaker, it saddens my heart, my good uncle from Agona Nyakrom, Goosie Tanoh, has been placed at the 24-Hour Economy Secretariat. He has been given GH¢110 million. That is less than US\$10 million. The President is saying that he needs to incentivise and transform our industrial base with a 24-Hour Economy with US\$10 million. How is he going to do that? I believe that we came to sit here for over three hours to listen to lamentations.

Mr Speaker, I remember watching the Vice President of the Republic, until the President made mention of the GH¢401 million, she never smiled. That was the only time she smiled. When we work the numbers, the GH¢401 million divided by 276 Constituencies, meaning that every constituent would get about GH¢1.4 million. But I remember then running mate, Professor Jane Nana Agyeman coming to my Constituency, she was in the Committee 9 market. She came to Committee 8 market. She was at Committee 4 market, promising them that she would give them money to work. When we do the tabulation, meaning that

each trader is going to get just about GH¢100. What are they going to do with the GH¢100? *[Interruption]*

Mr Speaker, the President also touched on the ORAL. We believe that they promised that they were going to retrieve some US\$21 billion. The President came here saying that they have gotten some 600 million, which is about 0.25 per cent. Who paid? Is it from Dr Duffuor's case or what?

Mr Speaker, about *galamsey*, I believe that this Government is rather empowering the DCEs and other NDC functionaries to destroy our water bodies and all our forest reserves. It will interest you to know that now cocoa farmers are chopping down the trees. The cocoa farmers are chopping down the trees because the President has motivated the cocoa farmers to sell their cocoa farms to *galamseyers*. In that, the President does not want to pay them what is—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Abed-Nego Bandim. Hon Member, you have five minutes, unfortunately.

Dr Abed-Nego Lamangin Bandim (NDC — Bunkpurugu): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute on the President's Message on the State of the Nation. Mr Speaker, let me focus on the telecom industry and demonstrate to you how the NPP Government for eight years ran down the sector in Ghana. H.E. the President of the Republic of Ghana, John Dramani Mahama, handed over a buoyant telecom sector to the NPP Government in 2017.

Mr Speaker, we had nine vibrant telecom operators in this country, and I can name them, if they have forgotten. We had MTN, that was doing very well. We had Vodafone, Airtel, Tigo, Glo, and Expresso. For broadband, we had Surfline, Broadband Home, and Bleu Telecom. In all, there were nine, and they were doing very well. But for eight years, their government ran down the sector, leaving us with only three as of today.

Mr Speaker, today, data and voice have improved in terms of value. Ghanaians pay less to access data and voice comparatively to other countries. For example, I can take you to Kenya, South Africa, and La Côte d'Ivoire, where we pay less in voice and data compared to the time that the NPP was in government. Mr Speaker, since 2017 till date, we have about 4.5 million Ghanaians living without telecom connectivity.

6:23 p.m.

For eight years, the NPP projected to build about 2,016 telecom cell sites. I can tell the House that they only managed to build and activate only nine cell sites in the whole country. Out of the 2,016 cell sites, we have been able to build 1,561. Out of 1,561, we have activated 1,441. If we go to our constituencies, we will find out that they are working and our rural folks now enjoy telecom services.

Mr Speaker, I am not surprised that the Ghanaian people have nicknamed H. E. the President “talk na do”. Because he does not only speak; when he promises,

what does he do? He delivers. The war between the United States of America (USA), Israel and Iran is about two weeks old. If it was in the NPP era, today we would have been saddled with excuses, with them telling us that it is because of COVID-19 and the Russia-Ukraine war. They would have lined up their communicators from the constituency to the Presidency to lament about the war in Iran. The Ghanaian economy is still resilient and working. It is still buoyant.

Let me say that they decided to re-register our SIM cards and for eight years it was saddled with fraud. Ghanaians had to wake up early as there were long queues, but they ended up giving us inaccurate data. Biometric enforcement was very poor. That is why we are going to do another SIM card registration.

Under the One Million Coders, thousands of Ghanaian youths have already been trained. We are looking to train about 400,000 more before the end of our tenure. If it was in their era—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Let us now move to Col (Rtd) Kwadwo Damoah.

Col (Rtd) Kwadwo Damoah (NPP — Jaman South): Thank you, Mr Speaker. H. E. the President came here. We had high hopes for him, and he addressed some of the issues critically facing the country. But the major one is unemployment.

Unemployment is a very big issue in this country. When we talk about unemployment, we deal with the public and the private sector as well. The public sector engages a lot more people than the private sector. So, the expectation is that more emphasis will be put on the private sector.

We know that agriculture is the backbone of this economy. When we talk about agriculture, you cannot forget about cocoa. The cocoa industry is the one that has kept this country for all this while. I have a constituency that has predominantly cocoa and cashew farmers, so anything that affects cocoa affects my people. This year, unfortunately, cocoa farmers have been overtaxed more than any other group of people in this country. If one has a whole thousand taken from their money for a bag of cocoa, then I do not think that Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA) can talk about any unfair taxation more than what has happened to cocoa farmers.

Now, we were expecting that with the establishment of the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA), more emphasis will be placed on providing industries that will help in promoting trade. We have the headquarters of AfCFTA in Accra. What we want is that we should encourage more people to engage in activities that will help us to produce enough for our local consumption and for exports. The facilities that the AfCFTA has provided requires that we do more in our country, so that the roots of our region will help us to enjoy the benefits of this important trade agreement.

Unfortunately, that is not what is happening. If we do not do that and continue to depend on imports, our economy is going to sink as we are seeing. We want the President to put more emphasis on local production. It can be in agriculture, it can be industry, it can be manufacturing or whatever. That is what we expect the President to do.

H. E. the President talked about retooling the security services, especially the Ghana Armed Forces, and I was pleased about that. We are going to have aircrafts, armoured personnel carriers, patrol vessels and all that. But we want quality equipment for the Ghana Armed Forces. There were times that we were having peace support operations in La Côte d'Ivoire, Bondoukou. Between 2013 and 2015, the armoured personnel carriers that were bought, which were to be sent to Bondoukou broke down. The brand-new ones broke down between Berekum and Jinijini and they were there for one more week than they were expected to be there. Certainly, that was not the right thing. So, the Ghana Armed Forces expect retooling. They want quality aircrafts, quality patrol vessels, and quality armoured personnel carriers.

Then about pensionable emoluments. Our soldiers who go on pension are supposed to be paid their gratuities and their monthly pensions. Unfortunately, because the Government lumped all of them together, about 3,000 at a go to be released, it became difficult for them to be paid, now we are putting the blame on not budgeting for them. It is because they

rushed and sent all of them home at the go. That has never happened, and that is a bad strategy.

The National Vaccine Institute. It was the former President and his able Vice-President, now the presidential candidate who brought that about. They passed a law to establish it and gave seed money of US\$25 million. Today, we are only hearing about promises, promises, promises. Nothing! Killer *ntua*! Nothing has happened. So, we want the President to invest more in vaccines. Put money there.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Col Rtd Damoah, I did not know that you could be this energetic. It is now the turn of Hon Emmanuel Ntekuni. Hon Member, you have five minutes.

Mr Emmanuel Kofi Ntekuni (NDC — Pru West): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for indulging me to comment on the Message on the State of the Nation.

I want to applaud H. E. John Dramani Mahama for his visionary leadership and his bold resolve to fix the health sector mess that was bequeathed to him to manage by the erstwhile NPP administration. When a visionary leader speaks, he inspires national development and unity by presenting compelling, hopeful, and clear future that resonates with the aspirations and hopes of the people. That is the hallmark of H. E. John Dramani Mahama.

6:33 p.m.

Mr Speaker, health is not merely health services. It is the backbone of national productivity. H.E. John Dramani Mahama had it right by saying that “I want health sovereignty; I want to do domestic financing of our health sector.”

Mr Speaker, we were here when donor agents’ support declined drastically from 19 per cent to paltry 2.2 per cent. We were here when USAID withdrew its support to the Ghana Health Service for essential health programmes. Mr Speaker, this was a defining moment because the gap of GH¢2.4 billion financing was left for H.E. John Dramani Mahama to decide on what to do. He had two options: either to lament or to lead. Mr Speaker, he chose to lead and he acted decisively.

Mr Speaker, the other Side of the aisle knows the importance of health sovereignty and domestic health financing and that is exactly what H.E. John Dramani Mahama did for this country. In 2026, direct financing of Government funding amounted to 72 per cent of the total health spending. What did they do? They did only 56.8 per cent. Core allocation amounted to GH¢23.3 billion, and if you put it together with the National Health Insurance resources, it amounted to GH¢34.7 billion of the total health spending.

Mr Speaker, this is not accidental; it is deliberate by H.E. John Dramani Mahama. It is a clear commitment to domestic health financing and health

sovereignty. Mr Speaker, we all know what has happened to the National Health Insurance. It is uncapped, hope is restored and confidence is boosted. People have enrolled and it has risen from 57 per cent to 66 per cent. Mr Speaker, claims are now timely paid more than before. Mr Speaker, this is reform in action. This is how we protect universal health coverage by funding sustainably.

Mr Speaker, before I conclude, we all know that these are measurable reforms. It is not rhetoric. From 56.8 per cent to 72 per cent domestic financing. Mr Speaker, from delayed National Health Insurance scheme claims to timely payment, from donor vulnerability to health sovereignty, from infrastructure stagnation to expansion, from neglect of chronic and non-communicable disease —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let him now turn to Hon Ampratwum-Sarpong.

Mr Kwaku Ampratwum-Sarpong (NPP—Mampong): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to contribute to the President's Message on the State of the Nation. Mr Speaker, President Mahama is somebody I admire on the quiet. Unfortunately, on the day he gave his Message on the State of the Nation, I ended up being very disappointed. I was disappointed because I was expecting him to speak and speak clearly on certain matters that have a profound influence on the lives of Ghanaians and the Ghanaian economy.

One has to do with the cocoa industry. I am a cocoa farmer, so what happened in the cocoa industry is something that is affecting my pocket, my well-being, my tomorrow, my health, that of my family and that of my immediate neighbours. So, I am a very worried and troubled man when it comes to the cocoa industry and the way President Mahama has been handling it.

The second point has to do with *galamsey*. It is *galamsey* because of the serious and terrible effects that *galamsey* is having on the lives, the future and the well-being of Ghanaians. I am a bit troubled because the NDC came into government on the back of *galamsey*. If we go to all the *galamsey* areas in Ghana as we speak, about 90 per cent have MPs from the NDC because they sold a story that the NPP were leading the charge in the *galamsey* industry and destroying the environment, the forests and the water bodies. Because the constituents bought into it, voted for NDC and they came and unfortunately, it is like the changing of the guards. Now the NDC apparatchiks have taken over *galamsey*. When we were in government, we were accused of leading the charge in *galamsey*.

Fortunately or unfortunately, the changing government has used it as its weapon and now, they are the ones in charge. Their Municipal Chief Executives (MCEs), Metropolitan, Municipal, and District Chief Executives (MMDCEs) are leading the charge in their various constituencies and areas and they are also using the District Road Improvement Programme (DRIP) machines to go and do the business. We

were expecting that, having said all that they said during the last term, the President, during his Message on the State of the Nation, was going to outline some practical achievable measures to arrest the *galamsey* menace. Unfortunately, it did not happen.

Now, what has happened is that the *galamsey* is also affecting the cocoa industry, which is so dear to my heart. The cocoa farmer has been given a double whammy slap; one, they are losing their cocoa farms to *galamsey* and two, the Government is also cutting down on the little money that they are getting for the small cocoa acreage they farm. That is my greatest disappointment. I am hoping that in the next two and a half years, President Mahama is going to take a serious look at the cocoa industry and at the *galamsey* menace to make sure that it brings some good relief to the lives of the many farmers in this country.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I would like to thank you for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I am sorry to do this, for the records, we have not taken over any *galamsey* activities from anybody. There is no single *galamsey* activity in Bia East, so I am not part — [*Uproar*]

6:43 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, please, if a Member says anything you are not — rebut it when you get the opportunity.

Other than that, we cannot make progress—We need to move on.

Very well, let me now move to Hon Kofi Arko Nokoe. Hon Member, you have the floor now.

Mr Dafeamekpor — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I would not want to do this, but it is just to guide our younger ones. There are strict protocols on the Floor here, so we may relax the rules. But we must, as much as possible, try to have regard to the protocols in terms of crossing the carpet, because there are people out there watching us.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, it is very important. It is only when we are at Consideration Stage and the Mace is tilted, then you can—So, Hon Shirley Kyei, just make sure you go through the other way.

Thank you very much. Yes, Hon Kofi Arko Nokoe, you have the floor now.

Mr Kofi Arko Nokoe (NDC — Evalue-Ajomoro-Gwira): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this profound opportunity to add my voice to the debate on the Message on the State of the Nation, ably presented by His Excellency John Dramani Mahama.

Mr Speaker, I believe that His Excellency the President himself summed everything up in his speech. So,

I refer to page 53 of the Message on the State of the Nation. In his words, he said,

“Mr Speaker, the State of the Nation is resilient. The State of our Nation is renewing. And our Nation is firmly in the hands of its people”.

Mr Speaker, we would all agree with all the statements made, that we inherited an economy that was in the worst of states. Mr Speaker, I am surprised that our Colleagues are always talking about cocoa. And surprisingly, the best brain, who was the CEO of COCOBOD for eight years, has now passed his speaking notes to his son to be telling us how we could have managed COCOBOD and the cocoa industry. Mr Speaker, what could they have done differently? For eight years, this same person ran down COCOBOD, and his son is now the one with new ideas to resurrect COCOBOD. What could they have done differently?

Mr Speaker, the mess that was caused was in all sectors, from infrastructure, to health, to education, and energy. Mr Speaker, when it comes to energy, a government that is serious about industrialisation does not play with the energy sector, especially, energy stability and domestic consumption. Now, what did we see when we came to power? An energy sector that was in coma, run down with debt that was being pushed along the way. But H.E John Dramani Mahama, the leader of this Government, as always, takes bold decisions.

Mr Speaker, for the record, when we came to power, there were issues with energy. I remember the former President say that they left the lights on. No, it was not true. Actually, the debt that we came to meet was GHC80 billion. And when there is debt, it affects everybody on the value chain, from generation through transmission to distribution. Now the good news is that, for investors to invest in our energy sector, that is, our crude oil exploration, we needed a guarantee. So, H.E John Dramani Mahama, in his own wisdom, put in place an insurance cover, which was US\$500 million, a World Bank partial risk guarantee.

The former government could not manage this. So eventually, investors were not willing to invest in our crude production, and that is why crude production declined to about 32 per cent. But I can say on authority, Mr Speaker, that as of December 2025, this Government, led by H.E John Dramani Mahama, has settled the US\$500 million World Bank facility, and because of this, investor confidence has returned to our oil production. Just last week, Tullow Oil and the Jubilee Partners have extended their production period, attracting an investment of US\$2 billion. This will lead to the drilling of at least 20 wells. It means that there will be more gas to power our electricity and there will be more gas for industrialisation.

Mr Speaker, what I am so happy about is the commitment of this Government to add value to our mineral resources. Every tonne of raw materials that we export, we are exporting jobs, we are exporting our prosperity and our

progress. VALCO, for example, for many years, was just exporting aluminium. Now a tonne of bauxite sells for US\$40 but finished aluminium products sell for US\$5,000. You can imagine, Mr Speaker, just a value chain at VALCO has added US\$7 million to the production of cables. And that—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Unfortunately, your time is up. You will get another opportunity, so let us turn to Hon George Aboagye. Hon Member, you have 5 minutes.

Mr George Kwame Aboagye (NPP — Asene/Manso/Akroso): Thank you, Mr Speaker for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, His Excellency the President was here to deliver the Message on the State of the Nation. Mr Speaker, the right state of the Nation is joblessness, of which everybody is aware, and I am surprised that my Colleague, Hon Nokoe, was talking so much about US\$2 billion oil, 700 million and so on.

But Mr Speaker, in his Constituency, that is the Nzema enclave, there has been a petroleum entity that has been established in this country. This petroleum hub needs only GH¢300 million to start operation. These investors are looking for land title for them to invest, and they needed GH¢300 million. But this Government is able to raise GH¢300 million to go and buy sanitary pads while this petroleum entity will employ not less than 800,000 Ghanaians when it is established. But we were able to buy sanitary pads. That is

the real state of the nation, to be able to raise GH¢300 million to go and buy sanitary pads, instead of paying compensation to the land owners for investors to have land titles. Mr Speaker, this is the real state of the nation.

Mr Speaker, again, the President in his message on the State of the Nation in 2025, said and Mr Speaker, with your permission, I read:

“Over the last eight years, the outgone NPP administration has left the Ghanaian people an energy sector burdened with a staggering GH¢70 billion debt as of December 2024”.

But in the Message on the State of the Nation in 2026, the same President in this House said the energy sector was burdened with a staggering GH¢80 billion debt. In 2025, he said GH¢70 billion; in 2026, he said GH¢80 billion. Which is which? Our Colleagues should let us know. Why? **[An Hon Member:** It is typo]**]**—It is not typo. This is what I found out, Mr Speaker. It is because they want to continue increasing electricity tariffs.

6:53 p.m.

That is why they are setting the mind of Ghanaians that there is debt we need to pay. That is why every year they are increasing the energy sector debt. Mr Speaker, now we have “Usain Bolt” meters in this country. Why do I say so? Last year, this Government increased electricity tariffs cumulatively to 28 per cent. In real time, we are experiencing

about 50 to 70 per cent increment and this Government is telling us that they will be able to get more revenue from this sector. It is just because of this increment. It is not because of any efficiency. There is no efficiency in that sector. The wastage in that sector is still there. They are in their second year and there is still wastage. If Ghana has to achieve energy security, we have to focus on wastage. That is the most important thing. Mr Speaker, so in reality, electricity collection has not been increased but it is because of the “Usain Bolt” meters that is why we are experiencing that so the Government must do that. This is the real state of the nation; Usain Bolt and then money to Nzema enclave for the Petroleum hub to move on. This is what we want. Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is Hon Alexander Hottordze’s turn. You have five minutes.

Mr Alexander Roosevelt Hottordze (NDC — Central Tongu): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I stand to support the Motion ably moved by the Hon Member for Bolgatanga Central, Hon Isaac Adongo and in so doing, I wish to thank H.E. President John Dramani Mahama for respecting Article 36(5) and Article 67 of the 1992 Constitution by delivering a masterful message on the state of the nation of Ghana. As Chairperson of the Select Committee on Trade, Industry and Tourism, I find this address to be more than a speech. In fact, it is a multidimensional strategic roadmap

designed to move Ghana from import-orientated to a position of continental trade leader.

Mr Speaker, conspicuously, every bit of information in this address is backed by data. For instance, the economy of Ghana has not only been recovered, but it has expanded by US\$113 billion, catapulting Ghana into the top ten economies of Africa. This particular growth is anchored on a sterling trade performance of Ghana. By December 2025, our current account recorded a surplus of US\$9.1 billion, which is 8.1 per cent of Gross Domestic Product (GDP), from US\$1.5 billion in 2024. The expansion in Ghana’s economy is attributable to the sterling performance of the economic policies of H.E. John Dramani Mahama. Mr Speaker, the US\$9.1 billion current account surplus, representing 8.1 per cent of GDP, indicates strong export performance and increased foreign exchange inflows, which is helping stabilise our cedi and reduce inflationary pressures. The foregoing undoubtedly strengthens investor confidence in the economy of Ghana.

Two, it also attracts investment into key sectors of the economy of Ghana. It creates opportunities for job and business growth. This positions Ghana as a resilient and competitive economy, capable of supporting development and improving the welfare of its citizens. Mr Speaker, the pillars of trade success indicate that the Government’s export-orientated strategy is yielding a remarkable result in Ghana today. Through the Accelerated Export

Development Programme, non-traditional exports surged by 27.04 per cent, generating US\$4.87 billion in 2025, while the mining sector alone contributed US\$15.25 billion, accounting for 65 per cent of total export earnings. The establishment of the Gold Board has strengthened gold sovereignty by formalising small-scale gold exports, increased recorded volumes from 63.6 tonnes to 103 tonnes, ensuring that the country's gold reserves support the national economy rather than leaking across borders.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Member. Let us now turn to Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib. You are a leader, but unfortunately you are supposed to use five minutes.

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, with leadership, we agreed on 15 minutes. *[Interruption]* Hon Richard Acheampong was not at Conclave. We agreed on 15 minutes for Leadership. Mr Speaker, that is fine. I can deal with the 10 minutes.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. I am just going by what has been provided to me.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, Members were supposed to do 10 minutes while Leaders do 15 minutes. So, that is reduced now to five minutes for Members; the Hon Member must do 10 minutes.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Shaib, you have 10 minutes.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, thank you for this opportunity. With your permission, let me first start by making reference to the biblical quotation, John 3:3 and with your permission, I read: "Jesus answered and said unto him, verily, verily, I say unto thee, except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God." Mr Speaker, this John 3:3 has a lot of permutations with H.E. President John Dramani Mahama. Let me just make a simple reference. This is the third time H.E. John Mahama has been made President of the Republic of Ghana. So, what it means is that he was President the moment President John Evans Atta Mills died, whose demise and how it happened, we have not been able to respond to till date. After President Mills' death, sorrowfully, sadly, President Mahama took over. President Mahama came back 2012 to 2016 and he is back again. He came to this hallowed Chamber and he said to us, Ghana is back. Mr Speaker, do you know what is back? Incompetence is back. Mr Speaker, do you know what is back? Deceit is back. And Mr Speaker, do you know what is back? Recklessness is back. Disregard for human beings is back.

7:03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I will show you how. First of all, let us start with the cocoa farmers. President John Dramani Mahama had the opportunity of canvassing for votes and he did so at the nooks and crannies of this State called Ghana. He went all over the place. Had a lot of time with cocoa farmers. He promised them that when he becomes the

President of the Republic of Ghana, wherever President Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo had kept them, he was going to move them further up. President Akufo-Addo left cocoa farmers somewhere around GHC3,100 per bag.

Mr Speaker, do you know what President Mahama did? He came and added GHC500, and they got GHC3,600. Do you know what is happening to them now? From GHC3,600, President John Dramani Mahama—*[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]*—has moved it from GHC3,600 to GHC2,500. And he has reduced the bag of cocoa just like they are doing in the Hisense advertisement, ‘*omo ate so sei huu*’. What is even more painful is that in these current and modern terms, the President had the effrontery, with all due deference to him, to tell cocoa farmers that he was going to construct boreholes. In these modern times, he tells cocoa farmers who farm on maybe 50 acres of land that he will construct a borehole.

Mr Speaker, if my time will be saved, that is all important. He can take all the 15 minutes if he wants to.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, my Brother, Jerry Shaib, the Second Deputy Minority Whip, said something that cannot be countenanced. He knows that what he said offends 93(5) of our Standing Orders.

Mr Speaker, with your leave, if I may remind you, Order 93 (5) is couched in these terms. “A Member may comment

on the statement for a period not exceeding five minutes, and the comment shall not provoke debate.”

Mr Speaker, he cannot suggest for the record that the “D”, the middle name of our President, sounds deceitful. He cannot do that.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Well noted. Hon Jerry, please withdraw that.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I have not said, and when did it become a problem for us to say in this Chamber, that people are deceitful? If I can prove to the effect that he said A, and he is wrong.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Jerry, I am requesting that you withdraw that.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I heed to your guidance and ask that it be withdrawn from the record.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, please expunge that from the records.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I just want you to know that I had spoken two minutes. Now it is four minutes, 34 seconds.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, you are continuing from four minutes.

Mr Shaib: No, I spoke for two minutes.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I took note of four minutes, but you continue.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, at this stage, for some of us who had the opportunity of benefiting from the COCOBOD Scholarship, we ask ourselves, what is happening to the cocoa farmer? The man who struggled to put some of us in school. Why are we doing this to them? Why did the President even promise the boreholes when they are dealing with acres of farmland? With deference to the President, if one has a farm that is about 50 acres in size, why should he construct a borehole to cultivate cocoa? Are we serious? Let me leave that.

Yesterday, we had some Statements read by the Minority Chief Whip, and it was on ecocide. And, Mr Speaker, that gave us a lot of information on how our forest is being degraded, and there is deforestation all over. Do you know why? Because we decided to change Precious Minerals and Marketing Company, and relabel it, which is very usual with this Side of Government, that all they are used to doing is to do rebranding, to now name it GoldBod. Now the Minister for Finance has also given it another name.

What are they doing? All they are doing is encouraging *galamsey*. Everywhere we pass, there is *galamsey*. There is an imminent death trap in Bole, where the President comes from, because of *galamsey* activities. *Galamsey* has become a problem to the extent that if we do not take care, including yourself, you will not be found alive in the next 20 years. What is happening? There are kidney issues, just like the Minister for Health even came to talk about. There is all manner of gallbladder cases, and what

we still think about is to make losses and to send people to London to go and have parties, and they will come and be celebrating, and then they will come and tell us that they have made losses of US\$214 million.

Today, the Deputy Minister for Finance comes to stand here and is talking about GH¢7 billion when we have made losses on gold of only about GH¢7 billion in 2025. And this is what we are talking about. Mr Speaker, let me just make reference to something that you would have to know, and you would be very excited to get this. And I picked this from the dailies and this was captured on the 27th February, and it says this,

“If you think *dumsor* was bad, wait until the Bui Dam falls. *Galamsey* silt is physically suffocating the turbines that power half of Ghana. We are trading 24/7 electricity for a few bars of gold today. It is a national security emergency. The people demand accountability. DCEs and MCEs in these gold mining areas, all they are doing is *galamsey*”.

Mr Speaker, this is the picture. [*The Hon Member showed a picture to Mr Speaker*] Look at that Bui Dam. It is getting terrible, and all we think about is mining and selling the gold, and then we send some set of women to London to go and chill with our money. That is what is happening. This is the kind of “settings” we are dealing with. Settings everywhere, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, now let me even give you some more. Under the leadership of President John Dramani Mahama, do you know what has happened? The Bank of Ghana sold 18 tonnes of our gold that we have reserved for all this period. And you know what they did? They amounted to US\$2.22 billion. In just about four months, they have come back. They sold the reserves. I watched the current Bank of Ghana Governor giving an interview, and he said that selling gold reserves amounted to we selling our future. He now had the opportunity, and he sold the gold reserves, 18 tonnes. Mr Speaker, look at this. Today, the Bank of Ghana is telling us that they are going to buy the same 18 tonnes of gold for US\$3.4 billion. When they just sold it for US\$2.2 billion? They sell it, release it, turn and come and take it. Who is taking the US\$1.3 billion dollars profit they are making?

Mr Speaker, we are here today, and we are talking about electricity tariffs. They came to Parliament to take what we call the *dumsor* levy, which is the 1 per cent on every petroleum product; they turn back, and all they are doing is *dumsor*—Mr Speaker, let me even finish with this. Do you know what happened?

7:13 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Jerry, thank you. Please, we made provision for this.

Hon Members, I am not a timekeeper. So, if, for whatever reason, there is an interjection and I allow that, yours will stop. Please, that is the

process, it is not me. We will all stop until the interjector stops, then your time starts counting again. So, that is the process. I have nothing to do with the time. Hon Jerry, for whatever reason, I will give you one minute. That is my benevolence —Hon, Acheampong, that is my own. He has one minute.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am extremely grateful to you. Mr Speaker, suffice to say, that I am rounding up, I will just bring up the issue on unemployment. I saw a post by President John Mahama in 2020, when he had posted that people were removed from their jobs and offices, and this was not the right thing to do. President Mahama takes over, and then he directs the Chief of Staff; 51,000 people were removed.

Mr Speaker, do you know why I am sad? I am sad because the Chief of Staff has presidential ambitions. Hon Johnson Asiedu Nketia will not ask that Ghanaians be removed from office like this.

Mr Speaker, these are people who are suffering from high blood pressure and other issues—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me now turn to Hon Joseph Appiah Boateng. Hon Member, you have five minutes.

Mr Joseph Appiah Boateng (NDC — Afram Plains South): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Message on the State of the Nation ably delivered by H. E. John Dramani Mahama, the President of the

Republic of Ghana, and Commander-in-Chief of Ghana Armed Forces. The gentle giant, the man with integrity, at least, if for nothing at all, no one can tag him with drug addiction.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Timekeeper, why is his time not reading?

Hold on.

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, the Hon Members started speaking about a minute ago, but we have observed that the time has not been moving, and we insist that it is deducted from the time allotted. So, he has about four minutes more. So, let the timekeepers keep track of that one.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, timekeeper, let us have the time working.

Mr J. A. Boateng: So, should I start all over?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Go on.

Mr J. A. Boateng: Mr Speaker, on 27th February, 2026, at 10 a.m., H. E. John Dramani Mahama was in the House to deliver the Message on the State of the Nation, and the Statement was so nice. I am proud of the President because, at least if nothing at all, no one can tag the President as a drug addict. He has done so well, and above all, he made mention of —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Appiah, please withdraw that statement.

Mr J. A. Boateng: Which one?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: That nobody can tag the President. Please withdraw it.

Mr J. A. Boateng: All right. I withdraw it.

Mr Speaker, during his address, he made mention of some projects in my Constituency, that is, Afram Plains South, and that he is going to construct a bridge from Adawso to Ekye Amanfrom, and continue from Ekye Amanfrom to Agordeke to construct our main road, and also construct a road from Kwamepong Nkwanta to Akyem Agogo, and again, as we speak, we have received over 10,000 chickens.

As I speak, Mr Speaker, an ultra-modern farmer's service centre, one in town, is being constructed in my Constituency. As we speak, the President has given the Afram Plains South District Assembly over GHC18 million. In 2024, the NPP administration gave only GHC300,000 to the District Assembly. So, the President is working. I do not know why some of them still want to dishonour what the President is doing.

Again, one will ask, why they hate everything that President Mahama does? Anybody who goes against President Mahama is a nation wrecker.

An Hon Member: Eeeii!

Mr J. A. Boateng: Yes, anybody who accuses him, that means they are a nation wrecker. As we speak, the Common Fund is not in arrears. We all

can attest to that fact. The National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS) is not in our arrears. The Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund) is not in arrears. Distribution of District Assembly moneys is not in arrears. Again, fuel prices have reduced drastically. Food prices have reduced drastically.

Mr Speaker, they left a gallon of fuel at GH¢90, now it is GH¢50, and they are benefiting from it. So, it has reduced drastically. There is no *dumsor* in the country. As we speak, the exchange rate that they left at GH¢47 [sic], is now at GH¢15 [sic]. So, is that the reason they hate him?

Now, if a person buys US\$1,000, they would use GH¢10,000 or GH¢11,000 to purchase US\$1,000. In their time, we had to use GH¢17,000. So, they are making free GH¢5,000 or GH¢6,000. So, if they do not like this—During their time, Ghana was being compared with Sri Lanka and Togo. Currently, do they know the countries that are compared to Ghana?

Mr Speaker, I say this with no apology whatsoever; sometimes, it is better to keep your mouth shut for someone to think that you are an idiot than open your mouth for them to know that you are truly the one. That is what it is —

7:23 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Appiah Boateng, I beg of you. Withdraw that one as well.

Mr J. A. Boateng: I withdraw it, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr J. A. Boateng: Mr Speaker, under President Mahama's administration, there has been no violence in by-election. We have not witnessed any by-election that has caused violence. Under President Maham's watch, Assembly Members are being paid every month. Under President Mahama's watch—

Mr Second Deputy Minister: Thank you very much. Let us now give the floor to Hon Patricia Appiagyeyi. Hon Member, unfortunately, you can use ten minutes.

Deputy Minority Leader (Ms Patricia Appiagyeyi): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Message on the State of the Nation which was presented on 27th February, 2026 by H.E. John Dramani Mahama. Mr Speaker, what we heard on the 27th of February as presented, was not the state of the nation. Let us be honest with ourselves in this House. What we heard was not the state of the nation; it was the state of political spin. It was not a diagnosis of the economy. It was a public relations exercise wrapped in statistics and decorated with slogans. The address was heavy on optics and it was light on outcomes. It was heavy on slogans, light on solutions; heavy on applause, and light on accountability. Mr Speaker, governance is not a theatre. Governance is delivery, and on delivery,

the Government is failing the people of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, the President presented figures, but figures without dignity are meaningless. You cannot pay rent with projections. You cannot settle hospital bills with optimism. This Government has perfected what is statistical governance where numbers rise on paper, while suffering rises on the streets? Growth without jobs is a jobless growth. Recovery without relief is rhetorical recovery. Mr Speaker, the true state of the nation is measured not in statistics, but in the daily dignity of the Ghanaian people.

Mr Speaker, it is basic economics. When purchasing power disappears, markets collapse. Today, farmers harvest their produce, but cannot find buyers. Market women sit from morning until evening and return home with unsold goods. Mr Speaker, just this weekend, I was at a funeral, and I met a market woman. She came to tell me that when I go to Parliament, I should let everybody know that they go and sit at their shops and nobody even enters to buy. This is the state which the President is projecting to us that Ghana has come back economically. Mr Speaker, small businesses are quietly collapsing. The informal sector, which employs the majority of our people, is suffocating. That is the true state of our nation today. Low inflation driven by weak demand is not economic success. It is economic distress disguised as stability.

Mr Speaker, the real state of the nation is outside this Chamber. It is in

traders battling with transport hikes, youth battling unemployment, SMEs battling high interest rates, and families battling utility tariffs. Electricity bills are rising, fuel remains volatile, and transport fare keeps soaring by the day. Rent in our cities have become unbearable. This is not an economic transformation. This is economic suffocation. The government promised a reset. What Ghanaians are experiencing is economic fatigue. This government preached austerity to the Ghanaian people, but where is the shared sacrifice? While citizens tighten their belts, the Government is losing its own.

We continue to witness bloated bureaucracies by establishing all manner things like the 24-Hour Economy Authority, expanded presidential staff, excessive appointments, and administrative extravagance. Mr Speaker, this is not fiscal discipline. This is hypocrisy. Leadership must lead by example, not exemption.

Mr Speaker, electricity tariffs have increased by 30 per cent. We cannot buy.

The President spoke proudly about agriculture, but farmers across the country tell a different story. Farmers are struggling! Farmers are struggling! There is high fertiliser costs, limited access to credit, inadequate irrigation, and post-harvest losses. That is what we are experiencing now and this is the true state of our economy. We have experienced cocoa haircuts. Farmers have their produce and unfortunately nobody is buying. The Government is not purchasing.

What are we experiencing? Mass dismissals. The only woman who had been in office, when we speak of affirmative action, that woman has been sacked, and it is very sad. I am talking about the Chief Justice, Justice Gertrude Araba Esaaba Sackey Torkornoo, at this point in time.

This is how—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I have not called you.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let me once more invoke Standing Order 93(5). The comments of a Member must not provoke debate. She makes the point that the only woman in office. It cannot be accurate that the only woman—The ex-Chief Justice was not the only woman in office.

So, Mr Speaker, my big Sister could go ahead and make her point, but the factual inaccuracies must be set aright.

7:33 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, I have not called you. If you speak tomorrow—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the respected Deputy Minority Leader made the point very clear that this Government dismissed Justice Araba Esaaba Torkonoo. It is a matter of fact. *[Interruption]* Forget that. He is not here

to mark grammar. He is here to mark the facts.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, I beg of you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: They sacked the woman. It was a political decision. Instead of creating jobs. It is inconsequential. *[Uproar]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Patricia Appiagyei, you may continue.

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, I would like to also emphasise that when farmers cannot cover their investments, they reduce production the following season and that is how food insecurity begins. Not with drought, but with a failed market and failed policy. Our cocoa farmers, once the pride of this nation, are now struggling to survive. Some are abandoning cocoa farms and others are selling land to illegal miners. This is not the agricultural practice that we know. It is a national tragedy. Our rivers are dying, our forests are disappearing, our farmlands are being destroyed. Illegal mining continues to poison our water bodies and destroy communities. Cases of kidney and respiratory diseases are rising in affected areas.

When young people see illegal mining as the only viable livelihood, it is not a youth failure. Mr Speaker, the youth of Ghana remember the promises; one job, three shifts. They have failed to recruit into the force. They were promised one job, three shifts. One Million Coders, industrial transformation, mass job creation, yet today graduates

roam the streets with certificate, but no opportunities. Thank you. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me now look up and call Hon Atta Issah.

Mr Issah Atta (NDC — Sagnarigu): Thank you, Speaker. Let me begin by thanking H. E. John Dramani Mahama for honouring his constitutional mandate in presenting the Message on the State of the Nation. The report covered a comprehensive scorecard of the President's first year in office, that is the year 2025.

Mr Speaker, this was a drastic recovery performance built on key pillars of our economy in terms of recovery from the fiscal and debt distress, currency and inflation stabilisation, external sector turnaround, and improved ratings and investor confidence going into 2026.

Mr Speaker, we cannot discuss the state of the nation in 2025 without paying attention to the pre-inauguration economy, that is the economy that was inherited from the administration of the former President, Nana Akufo-Addo. This was an economy that was burdened with unsustainable debt of GH¢726.7 billion after debt restructuring. It was an economy that was faced with high inflation of 23.8 per cent, which was high in the subregion. It was an economy that recorded 32 per cent depreciation of our currency against major trading currencies, the weakest in the subregion. It was an economy that had a felt reality on the average Ghanaian in terms of cost of living.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance and the President have eloquently discussed the macro issues, but listening to the Minority, they keep on repeating the same thing on electricity and water tariff, and I want to bring it to their attention. Never again should the average Ghanaian give the NPP the opportunity, having subjected us to these current economic difficulties and turn around to profit politically from the same difficulties that they put us in.

I have in my hand the International Monetary Fund (IMF) Country Report number 24/334 that was released in October 2024, and with your permission, let me quote:

“As part of Ghana's IMF support extended credit facility agreed in May 2023, a key prior action to the IMF programme, which was called a mandatory condition before the IMF financing, was to implement an upfront weighted average electricity tariff. The government was committed to implement an upfront weighted average electricity tariff adjustment of at least 29 per cent annually.”

What this meant was that every year, the minimum the Government could increase the electricity and water tariffs to was by 29 per cent. “This was explicitly meant to bring electricity tariff closer to the cost of recovery and reduce energy sector shortfalls.”

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Member on his feet must not attract any notoriety to himself. We do not want

the records of this House—He has just come as a young MP with a future. Mr Speaker, he must be careful with his choice of words to earn the respect of Leadership. He should be careful in using certain words, so that the House respects him. If he starts using certain phrases, he will lose the respect the House has for him.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, thank you.

Mr R. Acheampong: Mr Speaker, this kind of intimidation will not work in this House. He can never intimidate anybody in this House. He has decided to intimidate our Backbenchers but it will never work.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Acheampong? I think Hon Atta is even more fortified.

Mr R. Acheampong: Give it to them.

Mr Atta: Mr Speaker, I am still relying on the IMF Country Report number 24/334 for October 2024. It proceeds to say that “this covers the third review under the ECF...” — *[Interruption]* — Please, I am quoting from a report.

This covers the third review under the ECF arrangement. Outlined the programme's continued focus on utility tariff reform as a core component of the energy sector financial stabilisation. The report notes that the program envisaged periodic quarterly tariff reviews by the

PURC using a formal electricity and water measure tariff review 2022/2025 framework.

Mr Speaker, what this meant was that from 2022 to 2025, there should have been an annual increase in electricity and water by 29 per cent on an average, at least. Now, listen at what the IMF said, Mr Speaker. The IMF proceeded to say that—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Atta, I will give you 30 seconds. I gave the other one minute.

Mr Atta: Mr Speaker, let me just conclude with this. The IMF stated categorically —

7:43 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, as far as I am concerned, I try to be fair to everybody. Those people who were interrupted, at times, I give them one minute or 30 seconds. So please, I do not think I have been unfair to anybody. Now, we have had 12 comments each from the Majority Side and the Minority Side. I think on the Minority Side, I do not have any Members on my list. The Majority Side is left with only one comment. To be fair, if we can conclude—we are left with only Hon Fred Agbenyo on my list.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, many of the Members were not around when you mentioned their names, so I want to do replacements if they have the numbers.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, they do not have the numbers.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Majority Chief Whip and I have engaged. The conclusion is that we have had 12 Members to comment on each Side, so we should call it a day so that Leaders can prepare for tomorrow. We would want to encourage Hon Members to be in the Chamber. The understanding you and I had was that we would close at 12 Members on each Side to comment. If they want to plead for one more Member to comment, it is five minutes, and it is only fair that we will not take a pound of flesh. But know that it is only this time and this time only. They should not attempt to say that it is 12/13. This is just for you to know. I know how these people can take undue advantage of their so-called Majority. Remember, we once had 169 Members, and in 2028, they do not know what will happen, so they should be measured by how they enjoy their so-called Majority. They should be gracious. I am just reminding them. They never know what will happen. When they are taking advantage of their so-called Majority, remember that there is an election ahead, and Ghanaians are not happy with them. They cannot create jobs; they promised cocoa farmers GH¢6,000, but they cannot even pay them, and they are reducing—*galamsey* is getting out of hand—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member for Kpando, I will give you five minutes.

Mr Sebastian Fred Deh (NDC — Kpando): Mr Speaker, I thank you

sincerely for this great opportunity, coming at such an odd hour. Mr Speaker, let me use part of my time, as short as it is, to quote something that H.E. John Dramani Mahama said during the Message on the State of the Nation in the penultimate paragraphs. This is what he said, and I quote:

“Mr Speaker, there is an old African proverb, ‘However long the night is, the dawn will break’. The dawn is breaking for Ghana. The moment we are in requires not only endurance, but also action. It reminds us that renewal belongs to those who prepare for the morning, while others still speak of darkness—”

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader has developed a certain unholy taste for heckling my Backbench, both the female and the male, and he must desist from that. I thank you.

Mr Deh: Mr Speaker, the state of our nation, as said by the President, is resilient. The state of our nation is renewing, and our nation is in the firm hands of its people. This was said by H.E. the President, and I think that it is so inspiring.

Mr Speaker, I would limit my comments as short as it is on the industrial and trade policies that were so explicitly said or delivered by H.E. the President. He told us that this country's industrialisation and trade issues are anchored by the 24-Hour Economy Policy. This, for me, is unprecedented in this country, where you have a Policy

that has been brought forward to drive the economy, being brought to the Floor of Parliament for debate. If we have forgotten, let us remember that the 24-Hour Economy policy document, or the Policy as it is now, is a law. And this was brought to the Floor of Parliament and passed by this august House on the 6th of February 2025.

Mr Speaker, this budget is also anchored by a whopping amount of GH¢110 million, which has been devoted to the 24-Hour Economy Policy. The Policy document, unlike others that we have seen before, which have also come and gone, like the Vision 2020, Free SHS, and sloganeering policies that have come that we know about, none of this has been taken through, you know, a thorough process like what we have as a 24-Hour Economy. Indeed, Committees that are also part of this august House have scrutinised this Policy so well that now we can be proud that all the facets of lawmaking, and all the facets that require that a policy for a nation is taken or accepted by all, have been done.

Mr Speaker, let me remind all of us that as far as trade and industrialisation are concerned, per these policies, now we know that under the 24-Hour Economy Policy, we have extended operating hours backed by law. We have also gone ahead to negotiate for a reduction in energy and transportation costs. It is also part of the prescriptions of this Policy document, and by extending the law, we have a push for irrigated agriculture production, we have a GH¢250 million power deal savings that has been made through the

Independent Power Producers (IPPs) renegotiation, and we have all the other things that go with what we know as the Women Development Banking.

Mr Speaker, I heard a short while ago that one of the debaters was trying to make a point that the GH¢401 million that has been made for the Women's World Banking, if shared, some people will get some amount of money, which is GH¢1.00 per person. I think that is so—I do not know the word to use, but so rudimentary in analysis—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, that brings us to the end of today's debate. This is in preparation to end the debate tomorrow with the Leaders.

On that note, let me thank all of you, especially those who contributed to this session.

7:53 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we are grateful for the stamina shown by Members, especially, today being the last day for Members to make their final contributions on the Message on the State of the Nation. Tomorrow, we want to urge everyone to be here early, as our Leaders—There will be a tournament of ideas regarding the Message on the State of the Nation.

Today, we prayed to start at 12:00 noon, but we ended up starting at about 1:15 p.m. So, I pray that we come back tomorrow at 12:00 noon because both Leaders may have an hour apiece, that

would be two hours in terms of speaking time, before we deal with other Businesses. So, we pray that we come back at midday, so we can have enough time to handle other Businesses.

Mr Speaker, on that note, we have done a little over five hours. It is about three minutes to 8:00 p.m., so, we are entirely in your hands.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, thank you very much. Etse can be a true gentleman when he is in that gentlemanly mood, the way he chooses his words and all. It is my prayer that he continues.

Mr Speaker, there are two things. Tomorrow, I am told our women, our female MPs have a forum. I want to encourage Colleagues to participate. I am told it is 10:00 a.m.

Mr Speaker, also, a lot of Colleagues in this Chamber, I am Minority Leader. A lot of people would come to me with general concerns and I am passing it through the Majority Chief Whip. Mr Speaker, many of our constituents are having issues with the recruitment. They write aptitude test; they get logged out. They are spending money; it is unbearable and the pressure is on us. This Side of the House, that Side of the House, not one, not two, several MPs, Leader, put in a word for us. Mr Speaker, I do not know about you. The same thing? Mr Speaker, let the record hear you, that you are also having the same

issue. If you keep quiet, they will not know. When Afenyo-Markin says it, they say contempt. But I am speaking the truth. Every burden is on my head, from you; you people. You are suffering. You come, Leader, speak for us. Then when they are taking me to face the Committee of Privileges and Immunity, you will not stop them.

Mr Speaker, the truth is that — *[Interruption]* — No, it is a fact. Stop, let us not be partisan about everything. The truth is that the recruitment into the Police Service, the National Fire Service, the Prisons Service and the Immigration is becoming problematic. I do not want anybody to misinform the Minister. I am not directing any attack on his person. No, I just want to put the facts right. Do not pretend your constituents are not on your case. Mr Speaker, these unemployed youths go to the centre and are told they are supposed to go through aptitude test; they get into the system and are logged out. Somebody told me he was asked the question, what is the size of a basketball court? You want to join the Police Service and you are to answer a question—The AI system that has been deployed must be customised to ask relevant questions. It cannot be generalised. It is AI, so you are asking general questions.

Mr Speaker, the Ghana Armed Forces did something good. They created a system where people entered to write the aptitude test directly. If it is possible, the system should be changed to enable our boys and girls who are even not educated in ICT to write it manually so that a proper system is put in place which

will allow them to go into the AI space. I am for AI; I am for IT. But you cannot suddenly call somebody from Bunkpurugu who does not know anything about IT and once they join the force work, they are told to go and write aptitude test via AI and if they do not have any means, they fail.

Mr Speaker, this is not political and I do not want it to be misconstrued. I think it is a serious system challenge that the Ministry would have to look at properly because it is us, the MPs, who are carrying the burden. And I speak for the entire House. People go to the cafe and then they get on the computer and they go through all manner of challenges. I would plead that the whole system be reviewed. Our boys and girls come to ask MPs to take money to go onto the internet to have access.

Mr Speaker, I rest my case.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well noted.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Before my Brother seconds the motion for adjournment, Mr Speaker, let me say that I share in the concerns, the pressure on MPs. As we sit here, our phones are beaming with messages about disqualification. And so, let me assure the House and the entire nation that the Minister for the Interior, especially in respect of the services that fall under his supervision, is taking steps to address the issues. So, he is slated to come and meet Members on both Sides to iron out the matters. And I am sure that the Minority Chief Whip will be reaching out to the other Side regarding a convenient time

for the Minister to come meet them. The Minister is also taking steps to meet this Side so that we can engage and find a middle ground regarding the solution.

And let the records also reflect that this recruitment is the carryover from last year. It will not be the last. That is why everybody is asking for a more reasonable, forward-looking process so that going forward, the casualties will not be as many as they are. So, we are all looking for a more convenient way of doing it so that people do not feel that they have been left out unreasonably.

So let me assure the Minority Leader that where he sits, he has a certain panoramic view of issues. He will know that steps will be taken so that those who may not go through with this process, once the reforms are made can go through, especially those who have age on their side. That is that. The Minister will come and address the issue.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, when are we taking the formula for the Common Fund?

Mr Dafeamekpor: The indications are that we may take it by Friday. But I will confirm to the House tomorrow if I am able to confer with my two Leaders on the matter.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, this is the way to go. On that note, I am able to second his motion. Suffice to add that—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I do not think he moved a Motion. We have gone beyond the—Did you move a Motion? No, no, but you have gone beyond five hours and therefore, there was no need for—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we indicated that we are entirely in your hands.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, he was asking me to second his Motion so I wanted to tell him that, as his Senior, he knows how well the rules guide us. So, he cannot lead me into temptation to second a motion that he does not have the power to move. But Mr Speaker, with the positive response from the Chief Whip

8:03 p.m.

I believe that beyond this we may have to even look at the number of people who have bought forms and have gone through all this hell and whether there is a way that if they do not get the opportunity, they get their monies refunded. If they cannot refund then there must be a system to move them

next year. Yes, Mr Speaker, because over 250,000 people have bought forms, 90,000 plus went through aptitude test and we have been told only 5,000 will be taken. All those revenues—they come to us. That is a secondary issue, but for now I feel assured from his comment that the sector Minister will address this and terminate the system if possible or review it so that a proper way of testing—well, where I sit is a hot seat. Everything comes to me and I need to raise them. So, you must understand me.

Mr Speaker, people are suffering. That is the word on the streets. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, let me thank you once again. We have gone beyond 8:00 p.m., therefore I will adjourn the House. The House stands adjourned.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 8:08 p.m. till Wednesday, 11th March, 2026 at 12 noon.

Editor's Note

This *Official Report* was corrected by the House on 17th March, 2026.

Column 111, paragraph 3, line 5,
“agency” was deleted and “authority”
inserted.